

Biography of the Prophet Muhammad (s.a.w.)

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1. Seerah/ Biography

Definition

In the Arabic language the word *sīra* or *sīrat* (Arabic: comes from the verb *سار* *sāra* (Present tense: *yasīru*), which means to travel or to be on a journey. A person's *sīra* is that person's journey through life, or biography (a biography or simply bio is a detailed description or account of a person's life), encompassing their birth, events in their life, manners and characteristics, and their death. In modern usage it may also refer to a person's resume. It is sometimes written as "seera", "sirah" or "sirat", all meaning "life" or "journey". In Islamic literature, the plural form, *siyar*, could also refer to the rules of war and dealing with non-Muslims.¹ An autobiography is written by the person themselves, sometimes with the assistance of a collaborator.²

The phrase *sīrat rasūl allāh*, or *al-sīra al-nabawīyya*, refers to the study of the life of Muhammad. The term *sīra* was first linked to the biography of Muhammad by Ibn Shihab al-Zuhri, and later popularized by the work of Ibn Hisham. In the first two centuries of Islamic history, *sīra* was more commonly known as *maghāzī* (literally, stories of military expeditions), which is now considered to be only a subset of *sīra*.³

Early works of *sīra* consist of multiple historical reports, or *akhbār*, and each report is called a *khbar*.⁴ Sometimes the word *tradition* or *hadith* is used instead.

The Unique Features of Seerah al Rasul Muhammad (SAW)

1. The biography of the Messenger of Allah has come to us via the soundest academic methods and with the strongest proof – the sources of Seerah - which leaves no room for doubt concerning the major events of the Prophets life. This makes it easy for us to detect fabricated accounts. As we find the true events of Moosa (Moses) are mixed with the fabrications introduced by the Jews, and the life of 'Eesa (Jesus) is written from hundreds of Gospels which are officially recognized by the Christian churches—without any academic basis. They were not narrated through any chain of narrators that goes back to their authors.⁵
2. The life of the Prophet is well known at all stages, from marriage of his father 'Abdullah to his mother Aminah, until his death. We know a great deal about his birth, his childhood, his youth, how he earned his living before his Prophethood began, and his travels outside Makkah until Allah sent him as a Messenger. After that point, we know in more precise details all about his life.) year by year, which makes his biography as clear as the sun. This is something that is not even remotely available with regard to any of the previous Messengers.

¹ Raven, W. (1997). "SĪRA". *Encyclopaedia of Islam* (2nd ed.). Brill Academic Publishers. pp. 660–3. ISBN 90-04-10422-4.

² http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Biography#cite_note-1

³ Ibid.

⁴ Humphreys, R. Stephen (1991). *Islamic History: A framework for Inquiry* (Revised ed.). Princeton University Press. ISBN 0-691-00856-6. p. 83.

⁵ There are many dissimilarities among the Gospels which are recognized after hundreds years of 'Isa.

3. The biography of the Messenger of Allah tells the life story of a man whom Allah honored with the role of a Messenger. The Seerah does not try to make him more than human, or add myths and fables to his life. He is a great example for human being. Muhammad remained and will remain the perfect human example for everyone who wants to live a happy and decent life on the personal, family and social levels. Hence, Allah says in His holy Book: “Indeed in the Messenger of Allah [Muhammad] you have a good example to follow for him whose hope is in Allah and the Last Day...” (Qur’an 33: 21). Nevertheless we find not others’ biography as the exemplary ideal for human being as biography of ‘Isa and Buddha.
4. The biography of the Messenger of Allah includes all aspects of human life and interaction with society, which makes it the best example for every daa’iyah, every leader, every father, every husband, every friend, every teacher, every politician, every head of state, and so on.. We do not find anything like this comprehensiveness, not even anything that comes close, in what is left of the biographies of the previous Messengers and founders of ancient and modern religions and ideologies. Such as Moosa is the example of a national leader but we do not find in his life-story anything that makes him an example for warriors, teachers, politicians, heads of state, fathers or husbands. ‘Eesa represents the ascetic daa’iyah but he does not represent a war leader, a head of state, a father, a husband. The same may be said of Buddha, Confucius, Aristotle, Plato, Napoleon, and other great men of history. They are fit to be examples — if at all — in only one aspect of life where they achieved distinction and for which they are known.
5. The biography of Muhammad is the only one that can give us proof beyond any shadow of a doubt about the truthfulness of his message and Prophethood. It is the biography of a perfect man whose call went from victory to victory, not by way of extraordinary feats and miracles, but in a purely natural way. For he began his call and was persecuted; he conveyed his message and gained supporters; he was forced to fight so he fought; he was wise and successful in his leadership. The life-story of the Messenger of Allah proves to us that his message is true from a purely rational point of view. The miracles that happened to him are not the main reason why the Arabs believed in his call⁶. This is utterly different from the life-stories of the previous Prophets as preserved among their followers, which indicate that people believed in them because of the miracles and extraordinary feats that they saw at their hands, without thinking in a rational way about the principles of their calls, or submitting to them on the basis of reason.

Sources of Seerah

The Qur’an

The first and the most important source of seerah is the Qur’an. It is also the most eloquent and the most authentic source of the seerah. The Qur’an refers to incidents throughout his life and it refers to the people around him.

The Books of Hadeeth

All the books of hadeeth are considered an important part of the sources of seerah. Each and every

⁶ When the kuffaar of Quraysh insisted on demanding miracles from the Messenger of Allah, as the previous nations used to do, Allah commanded him to answer them by saying: “*And they say: ‘We shall not believe in you [O’ Muhammad], until you cause a spring to gush forth from the earth for us; Or you have a garden of date palms and grapes, and cause rivers to gush forth in their midst abundantly; Or you cause the heaven to fall upon us in pieces, as you have pretended, or you bring Allah and the angels before [us] face to face; Or you have a house of Zukhruf [like silver and pure gold], or you ascend up into the sky, and even then we will put no faith in your ascension until you bring down for us a Book that we would read.’ Say [O’ Muhammad]: ‘Exalted is my Lord! Was I ever but a human Messenger?’*” (Qur’an 17: 90-93)

hadeeth is either a saying, an action, an event, or a characteristic of the Prophet (Peace be upon him) and therefore it becomes a part of the life of the Messenger (Peace be upon him). It is a part of the overall seerah of RasoolAllah (Peace be upon him) and with the Qur'an this is where most if not all of the seerah's information lies.

The Classical Books of Seerah

These are books written by either companions or their followers from the early generations who wrote books which are specifically for the purpose of compiling the life of the Prophet (Peace be upon him).

1. The first physical book of seerah was written before any other book of hadeeth was compiled. Urwa ibn Az-Zubayr (d. 92 AH), the son of Asma bint Abi Bakr (d. 73 AH) and Az-Zubayr ibn Al-Awan (d. 36 AH) grandson of Abu Bakr (d. 13 AH), and the younger brother of Abdullah ibn Az-Zubayr (d. 73 AH), never got to see the Prophet (Peace be upon him). He wrote the first tract on the seerah that we know of.
2. Abaan ibn Uthman ibn Affan (d. 105 AH), the son of Uthman (d. 35 AH) wrote a small book on the seerah as well. Also Ibn Shihab Az-Zuhree (d. 124 AH) and Hamman ibn Munabbih (d. 101 AH), a student of Abu Hurayrah (d. 59 AH), wrote books on the seerah.
3. Probably the most popular and one of the most comprehensive of books known to is on the seerah is that of Mohammed Ibn Ishaq who was born in 85 AH and died in the year of 150 AH. He made it his life long passion to study the seerah. It was almost as if it was removed from the face of the earth, until recently. Some claimed that the manuscript of the seerah of Ibn Is'haq was found 20 years ago in the libraries of Germany. Only about a third or fourth of the actual book was found.
4. Abdul Malik ibn Hisham (d. 216 AH) wrote a book on the seerah and it was call Seerat Ibn Hisham . Ibn Hisham came and summarized the seerah of Ibn Ishaq. The irrelevant material from Ibn Ishaq as mentioned previously was discarded by Ibn Hisham in his seerah. Ibn Hisham mentions this in his introduction to his seerah and he only kept in his book whatsoever he saw important and necessary. When Ibn Hisham came out with his seerah it was so good and it became popular very quickly. Everyone who wanted to learn the seerah had this book and was starting to become more and more common and was being found in each and every household. Because of this, within a hundred years or so, Seerat Ibn Ishaq was no where to be found.

Shamaa'il

Another source of seerah is the books called shamaa'il. These are books written exclusively talking about the characteristics of the Prophet (Peace be upon him). In Arabic they are known as Shamaail. An example of this is the famous Shamaail At-Tirmidhee compiled by the great muhaddith, Aboo Eesa At Tirmidhee (b. 209 A.H. - d. 279 A.H.). It includes the characteristics and the physical description of the Prophet like the way his hair was, the way his eyes were, his walking, his talking, his dressing, etc.

Dalail An-Nabuwwah

These are books written about the miracles of the Messenger (Peace be upon him). Dalail An-Nabuwwah by Imam Al-Bayhaqee (b. 384 A.H. - d. 458 A.H.) is probably the most famous among them.

Biographies of the Sahaaba

The biographies of the companions serve to make the seerah more complete and to fill in some holes. They also give some of the vents surrounding it. An example of this is the story of Salman Al Farsee

(d. 35 AH) and his search for the truth which will be mentioned later. Also that of Jaafar ibn Abi Talib (d. 9 AH) and his conversation with Najaasee, the king of Abyssinia.

The Books of History

The books of history serve as another source of seerah. Examples of these books are, the book on history by Ibn Jareer At-Tabaree and *Bidaaya Wa An Nihaaya* of Ibn Katheer, *Tabaqaat* Muhammad Ibn Sa'd Manee'az.

Arabic Poetry

One of the matters concerning which there can be no doubt is the fact that the mushrikeen attacked the Messenger and message on the lips of their poets, which forced the Muslims to refute them on the lips of their own poets, such as Hassan ibn Thaabit, 'Abdullah ibn Rawaahah and others. The books of Arabic literature and the Seerah, which are subsequently written, include a great deal of this poetry, from which we are able to deduce much information about the environment in which the Messenger (saw) lived and the call of Islam developed at the very beginning.

2. Why should we study the Biography of the Prophet (SAW)

Allah's Messenger (PBUH) is the practical image of Islam. There is no way that one can get to know Islam without knowing Allah's Messenger (PBUH); his guidance, work, instructions and prohibitions. Allah's Messenger (PBUH) made peace and war, settled and traveled, sold and bought, took and gave. He never lived alone, neither did he travel alone. Muslims had weakened only because they failed to follow his pattern and guidance for the Almighty Allah said: {Indeed in the Messenger of Allah you have a good example to follow for him who hopes for (the Meeting with) Allah and the Last Day, and remembers Allah much } (Al-Ahzab:21).

Some Muslims went to the extent that they only read his biography (PBUH) during celebrations and forums without following his guidance. Some others read it either for obtaining blessings or for getting familiar with its events; wars, days.....etc. This happens due to one of two reasons:

First: their ignorance of the principal of following his pattern & guidance (PBUH) and not knowing that this is a necessity for achieving his love.

Second: their failure in perceiving the positions of guidance in his biography due to a weakness in their sense of conclusion or due to their lack of knowledge and readings. Here lies the importance of deriving the lessons and benefits from his biography (PBUH).

The biography of the Prophet (PBUH) is not meant to be taught for the pleasure of reading nor for the knowledge of a certain historic period and not for the love of studying the biographies of the grand and heroes. Such kind of superficial study is performed by non-Muslims. A Muslim should have various aims from studying his biography, among which are;

First: Allah's Messenger (PBUH) is the one to be followed for he is the example for all Muslims:

He is the legislator whom we are instructed to follow, for Allah says: {Indeed in the Messenger of Allah you have a good example to follow for him who hopes for (the Meeting with) Allah and the Last Day, and remembers Allah much } (Al-Ahzab:21); Allah (the Almighty) says {If you obey him, you

shall be on the right guidance)(Al-Noor:54); Allah also says {He who obeys the Messenger, has indeed obeyed Allah)(Al-Nissa:80).

And Allah also says {Say if you really love Allah then follow me, Allah will love you and forgive your sins)(Al-Imran:31). He is the practical image and incarnation of Islam without whom we can not possibly know how to obey the Almighty Allah or worship Him.

From his biography the scholars derive the techniques of the Call and its phases. They also get to know the tremendous effort exerted by Allah's Messenger (PBUH) for the sake of raising the word of Allah and how he reacted in facing the hardships and obstacles that faced him.

From his biography, teachers can derive the methods & techniques of education.
 # From his biography, rulers can derive systems and methodology of leadership.
 # From his biography, the ascetics can derive the meaning and essence beyond being an ascetic.
 # From his biography, traders can derive the aims, systems and methods of trading.
 # From it, those who are suffering can learn the highest degrees of patience and persistence, thus their determination can grow stronger and their trust in Allah increases knowing that the result will be finally in their favor.
 # From it, the scholars derive knowledge which enables them to better understand the Book of Allah (Al-Quran) and the various sciences of Islam, among which are the abrogating and abrogated verses, the reasons behind the revelation of verses and many other knowledge.
 # From it, the whole nation derives the morals, manners and merits.

Ibn Katheer said « a special care and attention must be paid to such type of study (the biography of Allah's Messenger (PBUH)) as it was narrated by Omar Al-Wakedi that Abdullah ibn Omar ibn Ali said that his father heard Ali ibn Al-Hussain saying: «we used to know the conquests of Allah's Messenger (PBUH) as we know the verses of the holy Quran».

Al-wakedi said, I heard Mohamed ibn Abdullah saying that he heard his uncle Al- Zuhri saying «in the science of conquests, lies both the science of life and that of the hereafter.»

Ismail ibn Mohammed ibn Saad ibn abi Wakkas said « my father used to teach us the conquests of Allah's Messenger (PBUH) and repeated them to us saying: «these are the glorious deeds of your fathers so waste them not».

History had witnessed many kings, leaders, poets and philosophers but none of them had left behind such a biography and such pattern to be followed as it is with the Prophet's. History had wiped off all their credit and the only thing left is some of their names.

Biographies of many grand people had turned out to be mere jokes throughout history. Where is Namroud who said to Ibrahim (PBUH) {I give life and cause death.)(Al-Baqara:258). Where is Pharaoh who said: {I am your lord, most high.)(Al-nazia'at:24), and what was his destiny» he who also said: {I know not that you have an ilâh (a god) other than me.)(AL-Qassas:38).

Those grand people of their ages are now being mocked by everyone; the young and the old, the knowledgeable and the ignorant, for if they had succeeded in deceiving their people at their time, their deception has been revealed and they became a mockery throughout time.

The biography of Allah's Messenger (PBUH) had provided the means for getting the people out of the darkness of polytheism and the corruption of worship to the light of monotheism and faith in Allah (the Almighty) who said: {O Prophet ! Verily, We have sent you as witness, and a bearer of glad tidings, and a warner And as one who invites to Allah by His Leave, and as a lamp spreading light. }(Al-Ahzab:45-46).

Second: An obligation

Allah has commanded us to know the Prophet Muhammad ﷺ. This is an obligation that Allah has put upon us. There are over 50 verses in the Qur'an that tells us to take the Prophet ﷺ as an example. For example,

Indeed in the Messenger of Allah (Muhammad SAW) you have a good example to follow for him who hopes in (the Meeting with) Allah and the Last Day and remembers Allah much. *Qur'an [33:21]*

From the Seerah, we can gain religious knowledge, we can learn about manners and morals. Also, from the Seerah, we get to know how he was as a leader. How he was as a father and as a husband. No matter in which angle we look at, we will find an example in him to follow.

Third: Love of Prophet Muhammad

Studying Seerah is the number one way to increase our love for the Prophet ﷺ. There are no other ways as effective and as powerful to increase our love for the Prophet ﷺ than by studying his life and times. This is a sad fact that unfortunately we have neglected this study.

If you truly love him, you will study him. Because, a sign of loving someone is to want to know more about that person. Studying the Seerah is a sign of love and through studying the Seerah we increase our love. It is a circle – the more we study the more we love, the more we love, the more we study.

Fourth: Helps us understand the Qur'an

Understanding the Seerah also helps us understand the Qur'an. The Qur'an is a very profound book and it cannot be understood without context. Without context, we cannot appreciate the Qur'an. For example, let us look at the following verse from the Qur'an,

Your lord has not abandoned you nor has he shown you any harshness. *Qur'an [93:3]*

We will not understand this verse until we study the Seerah – when it was revealed and why it was revealed.

Fifth: A source of optimism

The Seerah raises our hopes, lifts our spirits and blesses us with optimism. By studying the Seerah we can understand that the people before us suffered even more. In fact, in the Qur'an, Allah tells the Prophet ﷺ,

We are going to recite to you the stories of the previous prophets in order that your heart attain affirmation. *Qur'an [11:120]*

So, our Prophet heard the stories of the earlier prophets and it gave him optimism, increased his Iman. How about us then? Don't we need to increase our Iman even more?

Sixth: A miracle

The Seerah itself is a miracle of the Prophet . His whole life is an indication that he is the Prophet of Allah – coming from where he came, with the lack of education that he had and yet coming forth with the message, the eloquent scripture. The Prophet came from the midst of a barbaric nation and within twenty years or so after the first revelation, he revolutionized the entire nation.

The famous scholar Ibn Hazm says,

If the Prophet had not been given any miracle, other than his life and his times, it would have been sufficient to prove that he is a prophet from Allah.

His Seerah is the best indication that he is the prophet of Allah.

Seventh: A precise methodology for the revival of the Ummah

The Seerah lays out a precise methodology for the revival of the Ummah. If we want to bring about honor and glory to his Ummah, we have to look at what he did. He began from zero and within his lifetime achieved so much. We see the state of the Ummah today and our hearts bleed. We wonder why this is happening to us. The answer is in studying the Seerah and learning from it.

The Seerah brings about the knowledge with which we can defend the honor of our Prophet . His honor has always been under attack, from day one – he was called a magician, a madman and what not. The propaganda that began that time still continues. In our times the Prophet is called a bloodthirsty terrorist, a womanizer etc etc. How are we going to defend him if we do not know whether these things are true or not? And if certain elements are true, then how do we understand them?

By studying Seerah, we can also learn about the lives of the companions. They are called the best of generations, as mentioned in the Qur'an,

Allah being pleased with them and they with Him. *Qur'an [98:8]*

By studying the Seerah, we study the stories of Abu Bakr and Umar and Ali, the stories of Anas and Jabir, Talha and Jubair – they were all legendary people. They inspire us by their sacrifices, struggles, patience and perseverance. Each and everyone of them is a role model for us

3. Jahiliyyah

Jahiliyyah is an Arabic word means ignorance, foolishness, irrationality, unintelligence, inexperience, mental incapacity, lack of education, darkness, crudeness, to pretend not to know etc. It is used for “ignorance of divine guidance” or “the state of ignorance of the guidance from Allah”⁷ or “Days of Ignorance”⁸ referring to the condition in which Arabs found themselves in pre-Islamic Arabia (in the non-Islamic sense), i.e. prior to the revelation of the Quran to Muhammad. Malik Bennabi said: the term *Jahilliyyah* refers to the pre-Islamic society in the Arabian Peninsula. They are a society plagued with ignorance, rejected Allah SWT guidance, had no moral values, had no civilization, could not read or write and were disobedient to the laws of Allah SWT (Mahmud Syakir, 1991:10; Malik Bennabi, 2009:65)⁹

Jahiliyya in the Quran and Sunnah

The term *jahiliyyah* is used several places in the Quran, and translations often use various terms to represent it. The Qur'an said:

“Say, ‘Do you order me worship other than Allah, O *Jahilun*?’” (Al-Zumar: 64)

That is, to worship other than Allah, is to adopt a *jahiliyy* position. And,

“Do they seek the judgment of the Jahiliyyah? But- for a people who believe - who can be better than Allah for judgment?” (Al-Mayeedah: 50)

That is, to live by Laws and Commandments other than the Qur'anic Revelation, or seek judgments and rulings from other than it, is *Jahiliyyah*.

Similarly, to hold wrong opinions about Allah, or against the truths of life, or to be concerned with oneself when a community affair is involved, is Jahiliyyah. The Qur'an described it:

“Then, after the distress ... But a party was there that was only concerned with itself, imagining untrue things about Allah – Jahiliyy imaginations - asking: ‘Is there any say for us in the affair?’ Tell them: ‘The affair belongs entirely to Allah.’ (3:154)

The term was also used by the Prophet on various occasions. He said: “He who refused obedience (of an ameer proper), disavowed the Jama'ah (the mainstream Muslims), and then died, died on jahiliyyah. And he who fought blindly under a banner, getting angry for a prejudicial group, inviting to blind solidarity, or helped a prejudicial group and was killed ... then, his death was a Jahiliyy death.”

Historical concept

This term can be used in reference to the Arabic culture before the arrival of Islamic Revelation. The Arab *Jahilliyyah* society lived in the Arabian Peninsula in the period after the destruction of the Ma'arib Damp in Saba in the year 300 AD . The duration of this *Jahilliyyah* period is about 310 years beginning from 300 AD until 610 AD. The Arab society that lived during this period were known as Arab *Jahilliyyah* as they did not follow the teachings of the earlier Prophets and Messengers such as Prophet Sulaiman (as), Prophet Ibrahim (as), Prophet Isma'il (as), Prophet Musa (as), Prophet Isa (as) and others (Akashah Ismail, 2003:85). The *Jahilliyyah* period is regarded as the dark period. At that time the Arab *Jahilliyyah* did not worship Allah SWT the One and Only. In fact most of them worshipped idols and believed in animism. The Arab *Jahilliyyah* society lived chaotically as there

⁷ Qutub, Sayyed, Millstone, pp.11-19

⁸ G.S.P. Freeman-Grenville, *Islam: An Illustrated History*, p. 27

⁹ Mahmud Syakir (1991). *Al-Tarikh al-Islamiy Qabl al-Bi'thah*, Jld. 1. Beirut: Al-Maktab al-Islamiy. Malik Bennabi (2009). *Asal Usul Masyarakat Manusia Rangkaian Hubungan Sosial (On The Origins of Human Society)*, transl. Muhammad Uthman El-Muhammady. Kuala Lumpur: Institut Terjemahan Negara Malaysia Berhad.

were no Prophet or Messenger and holy books that could be used as a guidance in their life at that time. Their good manners were almost non-existent, for example they were cruel, proud and stubborn (Mahmud Syakir, 1991:10). With the advent of Islam in the year 610 AD, the Arab *Jahilliyyah* society started to change. All aspects of their life were shaped by the Islamic *tasawwur* (worldview) which encompassed aspects of *aqidah* (faith), *ibadah* (worship) and *akhlaq* (manners).

Some say Jahiliyyah period is about 100 years before the prophethood of Muhammad (saw) or some say is beginning from departure of 'Isa (as).

Jahiliyya in contemporary society

Use of the term for modern Muslim society is usually associated with Qutb's other ideas namely that reappearance of *Jahiliyya* is a result of the lack of Shari'a law, without which Islam cannot exist;¹⁰ that true Islam is a complete system with no room for any element of *Jahiliyya*;¹¹ that all aspects of *Jahiliyya* ("manners, ideas and concepts, rules and regulations, values and criteria") are "evil and corrupt"¹²

Non-Muslim societies may also be termed *jahili*.

The Arab Jahilliyyah Society

As mentioned above, the Arab *Jahilliyyah* society did not devote themselves to Allah SWT, whether in the aspects of faith, worship or manners (Malik Bennabi, 2009:60-61). In other words their life was not based on *tauhid* (oneness of Allah SWT). All their actions and practices were shaped solely by their minds and desires. With such a worldview, the Arab *Jahilliyyah* characteristics could be discerned from the few following aspects:-

a. Religion and Belief

In the Arab *Jahilliyyah* society, the rejection to any form of religion could be due to a few factors.

1. First they did not believe the Prophets and Messengers sent by Allah SWT in the period before;
2. Second they changed the contents of the *Taurat* that was brought by Prophet Musa (as).;
3. Third there was no particular Prophet or Messenger and holy book that were sent specifically for them;
4. Fourth the spread of various religions within the Arabian Peninsula, the Persians spread the Magi religion whereas the Romans spread Christianity; and
5. Fifth there were some quarters who brought back external religions into Mecca. For example. Umar bin Luai who had gone to Syams and saw the Balqa sect worshipping idols and thus brought back the religion to Mecca (Ibn Kathir, 1989:174).¹³ The effect was that Mecca became the centre for worshipping idols at the time.

The religious sect on the other hand could be categorized into 5 sections that is Wathani (Idolaters), Christianity, Magi, Jews and *Hanif* (Monotheist). Besides that a part of the Arab *Jahilliyyah* society practiced animism such as belief in the spirits, protector, unseen powers, sun worshipping and tree worshipping. There were also beliefs that were regarded as nonsensical and imaginative such as fortune telling and observing the direction of birds flying. If the birds flew in the left direction then it is an omen that the journey was perilous and not safe and *vice versa*.

b. Social

¹⁰ Qutb, *Milestones*, p.9, 82

¹¹ Qutb, *Milestones*, p.32, 47

¹² Qutb, *Milestones*, p.9, 132

¹³ Ibn Kathir, Abi al-Fida al-Hafiz al-Dimasyqiyy. (1989). *Al-Bidayah wa al-Nihayah*, Vol. 2. Beirut, Lubnan: Dar al-Kutub al-Ilmiyyah.

The Arab *Jahilliyyah* society was generally divided into two groups, those are the Bedouin and the *Hadhari* (Civilized) society.

- The Bedouin lived in the valleys and upcountry, that is in the middle of the Arabian Peninsula.
- The *Hadhari* society on the other hand lived along the coast of the Arabian Peninsula. The differences in their settlement indirectly affected their different ways of life and achievements.

In addition the Arab *Jahilliyyah* society was made up of various clans and tribes. Such situation provided a number of negative effects. Among them is the emergence of '*asabiyyah* (extreme feeling of closeness to one's clan and tribe) and resulted usually in the onset of war within the society. The emergence of this '*asabiyyah* was due to the set up that was based on clans and tribes. Each clan lived with their groups and were bound to abide to rules set by the clan. This has further solidified the feeling of clanship within clan members. They were prepared to seek revenge to safeguard their self-respect and clan. Besides that the emergence of such social traits were closely related to the geographical circumstances that they lived in which was very hot and dry. In ensuring survival, each clan would need to overcome the problems collectively. The solidification towards the feeling of clanship had resulted in the Arab *Jahilliyyah* life to be chaotic and disordered. This usually became the source of animosity within the Arab *Jahilliyyah* society. War between differing clans could exist even on trivial grounds. The al-Basus war between the Bakr clan and Rab'ah exhibited a trait of the Arab *Jahilliyyah* society that took pleasure in fighting one another.

Furthermore women were not given the status they deserved whether within the family or the society. They regarded daughters upon reaching full age as plaguing them with social and economical problems. As such the Arab *Jahilliyyah* society were willing to bury their daughters alive such as was prevalent in the Tamim and Asad clans. They also wed without any limit.

c. Economy

The destruction of the Ma'arib Dam in Yemen had brought about a decline in the economy. Agricultural yield decreased badly due to the poor irrigation system. The northern part consisted of the desert. As such trading activities were conducted in Mecca, Hirah and Ghassan. However trading was not profitable due to the bickering amongst clans. The Quraisy exploited trade and practiced usury and suppression. They pressured the Bedouin who lived in the desert. In retaliation the Bedouin robbed the Quraisy's caravans. Actually the main economics activities of the Bedouin were rearing cattle's nomadically such as camels, goats and sheep. They migrated constantly in search for greener pastures for their livestock. Their economics activities symbolized a primitive life.

d. Politics

During the *Jahilliyyah* period none of the governments had a systematic and strong administration. Politics were jeopardized due to colonization. The north was governed by the Roman and Persian empires, whereas the south was governed by the Habsyah (Euthopia) government. Mecca was badly affected by these conquests. The political climate of these colonized areas such as in Ghassan, Hirah and Yemen were unruly. The society lived by tribes and were regularly at war with one another. Although the country had its own administration nonetheless it could not be regarded as an advanced or civilized government because it was under the colonialists.

4. The Date of the Prophet's Birth

It is a commonly held belief that the birth-date of the Prophet (s. a.s.) is the 12th of Rabi al-Awwal, in the Year of the Elephant, which is the year that the Abyssinian Emperor Abraha attacked the Ka'bah

with an army of elephants. However, most Muslims are unaware that there has always been great controversy over the precise date of the Prophet's birth, and it is quite possible that the 12th of Rabi al-Awwal is not in fact the strongest opinion on the matter.

There is no narration in the famous 'Eight Books'¹⁴ of *ahadith* that specifies when the Prophet s. a. s. was born. Rather, the only narration that exists specifies the day he was born, and not the date. We would like to mention the different opinions on the date of Prophet's birth.

1. Monday, 10th of Rabi al-Awwal¹⁵, the 'Year of the Elephant'.
2. Monday, 8th of Rabi al-Awwal¹⁶,
3. Monday, 2nd of Rabi al-Awwal¹⁷.
4. Monday, no precise date¹⁸.
5. The 'Year of the Elephant', no precise date¹⁹.
6. 12th of Rabi al-Awwal.²⁰
7. 17th of Rabi al-Awwal.²¹
8. 22nd of Rabi al-Awwal.²²
9. The month of Ramadan, without a specific date, in the 'Year of the Elephant'²³.
10. 12th of Ramadan, in the 'Year of the Elephant'. This opinion was reported by Ibn Asakir as being held by some early authorities.

These are the most predominant opinion regarding the date of the Prophet's *salla Allahu alayhi wa sallam* birth. However, this is by no means comprehensive – for example, a modern researcher has concluded that the 9th of Rabi al-Awwal is the strongest candidate for the exact date, whereas a few earlier authorities even disputed the very year, claiming that it was ten, or twenty-three, or forty years after the 'Year of the Elephant'

Why is the opinion of the 12th of Rabi al-Awwal so popular?

This can be explained, and Allah knows best, by two factors. **Firstly**, the popularity of Ibn Ishaq himself. His book of *sirah* is a primary source of information regarding the biography of the Prophet *salla Allahu alayhi wa sallam*. **Secondly**, the first time that a group of people decided to take the birthday of the Prophet as a public day of celebration (i.e., the inception of the celebration of the *mawlid*), it so happened that they chose this opinion (viz., the 12th of Rabi al-Awwal). Hence, when the practice of the *mawlid* spread, so did this date.

5. Hilf al-Fudul

Hilf al-Fudul (Arabic: **حلف الفضول**) was a 7th-century alliance created by various Meccans, including the prophet Muhammad, to establish fair commercial dealing. Because of Muhammad's role in its

¹⁴ Bukhari, Muslim, Nasa'i, Abu Daud, Ibn Majah, Tirmizhi, Mu'atta, Musnad Ahmad

¹⁵ This has been reported by Ibn Asakir (d. 571 AH) from Abu Ja'far al-Baqir (d. 114 AH), a descendant of the Prophet and an alleged imām of the Shites. It is also the opinion of al-Shaba (d. 100 AH), a famous scholar and student of the Companions, and al-Waqidi (d. 207 AH) himself.

¹⁶ This was the opinion of the Andalusian scholar Ibn Hazm (d. 456 AH), and many of the early scholars. Imam Malik (d. 179 AH) reported this opinion from al-Dhuhr (d. 128 AH) and Muhammad b. Jubayr b. Mut'im (a famous Successor), amongst others.

¹⁷ This was the preferred opinion of Abu Mashar al-Sindi (d. 171 AH), one of the earliest scholars of *sirah*, and of the famous *Maliki* jurist and scholar, Ibn Abd al-Barr (d. 463), Ibn Kathir (d. 774), states in his *al-Bidaya wan Nihayah* that the majority of scholars believed that the Prophet was born in the month of Rabi al-Awwal.

¹⁸ Abu Qatada narrates that a Bedouin came to the Prophet and asked him about fasting on Monday, to which the Prophet replied, "That is the day I was born on, and the day that the revelation began" [Narrated by Muslim].

¹⁹ Suwayd b. Ghafla narrated, "The Prophet and I were born in the same year, the 'Year of the Elephant.'" Sunan of al-Bayhaqi [vol. 1, p. 79]

²⁰ This is the opinion of Ibn Ishaq (d. 150), who reported it without any reference.

²¹ This was the opinion of some Shiite scholars, and is rejected by most Sunni authorities.

²² This opinion has also been attributed to Ibn Hazm

²³ This was the opinion of the famous early historian al-Zubayr b. al-Bakkar (d. 256), who wrote the first and most authoritative history of Makkah, and some early authorities agreed with him.

formation, the alliance plays a significant role in Islamic ethics. Because *fudul* commonly means “virtuous” the alliance is often translated as League of the Virtuous.²⁴

Historical background

Muhammad [pbuh] was hardly fifteen when the ‘sacrilegious’ wars — which continued with varying fortunes and considerable loss of human life for a number of years — broke out between Quraish and Banu Kinana on the one side and Qais ‘Ailan tribe on the other. It was thus called because the inviolables were made violable, the prohibited months being included. At the conclusion of these wars, when peace was restored, people felt the need for forming confederacy at Makkah for suppressing violence and injustice, and vindicating the rights of the weak and the destitute. Representatives of Banu Hashim, Banu Al-Muttalib, Asad bin ‘Abd Al-‘Uzza, Zahrah bin Kilab and Taim bin Murra were called to meet in the habitation of an honorable elderly man called ‘Abdullah bin Jada‘an At-Taimy to enter into a confederacy that would provide for the above-mentioned items. The Messenger of Allâh [pbuh] shortly after he had been honored with the ministry of Prophethood, witnessed this league and commented on it, with very positive words: “I witnessed a confederacy in the house of ‘Abdullah bin Jada‘an. It was more appealing to me than herds of cattle. Even now in the period of Islam I would respond positively to attending such a meeting if I were invited.”²⁵

Yemeni merchant

A Yemeni merchant from Zabid had sold some goods to a notable member of the clan of Sahm. Having taken possession of the goods, the man from Sahm refused to pay the agreed price. The wrong doer knew very well that the merchant had no confederate or kinsman in Mecca, whom he could count upon for help. But the merchant, instead of letting it pass, appealed to the Quraysh to see that justice was done.²⁶

Formation

In response a meeting was hosted at the house of Abdullah ibn Ja‘dan.²⁷ At the meeting, various chiefs and members of tribes pledged to:²⁸

- respect the principles of justice, and
- collectively intervene in conflicts to establish justice.

To make the pact imperative and sacred, the members went into the Ka'aba and poured water into the receptacle so it flowed on the black stone. Thereupon each man drank from it. Then they raised their right hands above their heads to show they would stand together in this endeavor.²⁹ The pact was written and placed inside the Ka'aba, the place where the participants believed it would be under the protection of God.³⁰

Among the members who agreed to the terms of the pact was the Islamic prophet Muhammad. Later on, after proclaiming Islam, Muhammad still acknowledged the validity of the pact, ignoring the fact that most of the members were non-Muslim.³¹ Abu Bakr is also said to have agreed to this pact.³² This presumption is based on the fact that Abdullah ibn Ja‘dan, whose house was the venue for this pledge, was Abu Bakr's fellow clansman. Amongst the clans, Banu Hashim, Banu Zuhra and Banu Taym

²⁴ Ibrahim, Mahmood (Aug., 1982). “Social and Economic Conditions in Pre-Islamic Mecca.” *International Journal of Middle East Studies*, 14(3): 355. [Cambridge University Press](#)

²⁵ Ibn Hisham 1/113,135

²⁶ Ibrahim, Mahmood (Aug., 1982). “Social and Economic Conditions in Pre-Islamic Mecca.” *International Journal of Middle East Studies*, 14(3): 355. [Cambridge University Press](#)

²⁷ Najeebabadi, Akbar Shah. *The History of Islam*. Darussalam publishers. p. 101

²⁸ Ramadan, Tariq (2007). *In the footsteps of the prophet*. p. 20-2

²⁹ Lings, Martin (1983). *Muhammad: His Life based on the earliest Sources*. p. 31-2

³⁰ Chelhod, Joseph (Nov., 1991). “La foi jurée et l'environnement désertique.” *Arabica*, 38(3): 301.

³¹ Ramadan, Tariq (2007). *In the footsteps of the prophet*. p. 20-2

³² Ibid.

participated in its formation. Neither the Banu Nawfal, nor the powerful Banu Umayya took part in it.[1]

That pact also marked the beginning of some notion of justice in Mecca, which would be later repeated by Muhammad when he would preach Islam.³³ Another aspect of the pact was that it would open up the Meccan market to Yeminite merchants, who were hitherto excluded.³⁴ Nevertheless, the pact was considered “superficial and that which has no primary significance.” It is said that some Quraysh went as far as excluding the participants from their rank.³⁵

Legacy

Husayn ibn Ali once threatened the Medinan governor, who Hussayn believed gave an unjust decision, that he would take the case to the members of Hilf al-Fudul.³⁶

Anas Malik sees the pact as example libertarianism in Islam,³⁷ and Anthony Sullivan considers it as a support for Muslim democrats.³⁸

Islamic ethics

The pact holds significance in Islamic ethics. According to Anthony Sullivan, the pact represents Islam's interest in human rights and protection of such rights.³⁹ Muhammad, later as a Muslim, accepted the substance of the agreement made by primarily non-Muslims. Tariq Ramadan draws three principles from this:⁴⁰

- Islam embraces values derived from the human conscience, that are outside of the Islamic tradition. This is because Muhammad had acknowledged a pact before revelation, in the pre-Islamic era.
- Islam acknowledges the righteousness of non-Muslims. In this case, the non-Muslims had defended justice and the oppressed.
- Islam, instead of building allegiance to a closed community, requires allegiance to a set of universal principles. The message of Islam is not a closed value system, or at variance or conflict with other value systems.

6. Phases and Stages of the Call during Makkan life

The Muhammadan Call could be divided into two phases distinctively demarcated:

1. The Makkan phase: nearly thirteen years.
2. The Madinese phase: fully ten years.

Each of the two phases included distinctive features easily discernible through accurate scrutiny into the circumstances that characterized each of them.

The Makkan phase can be divided into three stages:

1. The stage of the secret Call: three years.
2. The stage of the proclamation of the Call in Makkah: from the beginning of the fourth year of Prophethood to almost the end of the tenth year.

³³ Peterson (2006), p. 43

³⁴ Watt, W. M. *Muhammad: Prophet and Statesman*. Oxford University Press. p. 9

³⁵ Ibrahim, Mahmood (Aug., 1982). “Social and Economic Conditions in Pre-Islamic Mecca.” *International Journal of Middle East Studies*, 14(3): 355. Cambridge University Press

³⁶ By M Th Houtsma. *E.J. Brill's First Encyclopaedia of Islam, 1913-1936*. p. 307

³⁷ Malik, Anas. *The Case for Minarchist Libertarian Political Islam*. Presented at Yale University's Critical Islamic Reflections conference.

³⁸ Sullivan, Antony T. *Islam, America, and the political economy of liberty*

³⁹ Ibid.

⁴⁰ Ramadan, Tariq (2007). *In the footsteps of the prophet*. p. 20-2

3. The stage of the call to Islam and propagating it beyond Makkah: it lasted from the end of tenth year of the Prophethood until Muhammad's [pbuh] emigration to Madinah.

The Madinese phase will be considered later in its due course.

The First Stage: Strife in the Way of the Call

Three Years of Secret Call

It is well-known that Makkah was the centre for the Arabs, and housed the custodians of Al-Ka'bah. Protection and guardianship of the idols and stone graven images that received veneration on the part of all the Arabs lay in the hands of the Makkans. Hence the difficulty of hitting the target of reform and rectitude in a place considered the den of idolatry. Working in such an atmosphere no doubt requires unshakable will and determination, that is why the call unto Islam assumed a clandestine form so that the Makkans should not be enraged by the unexpected surprise.

The Early Converts

The Prophet [pbuh] naturally initiated his sacred mission right from home and then moved to the people closely associated with him. He called unto Islam whomsoever he thought would attest the truth which had come from his Lord. In fact, a host of people who nursed not the least seed of doubt as regards the Prophet [pbuh], immediately responded and quite readily embraced the true faith. They are known in the Islamic literature as the early converts.

Khadijah, the Prophet's spouse, the mother of believers, was the first to enter the fold of Islam followed by his freed slave Zaid bin Harithah, his cousin, 'Ali bin Abi Talib, who had been living with him since his early childhood, and next came his intimate friend Abu Bakr As-Siddiq (Abu Bakr the truth verifier).

The Quraishites learn about the Call

This stage of the Call, even though conducted in a clandestine manner and on an individual basis, its news leaked out and assumed a public interest all over Makkah. In the beginning, the Makkan leaders did not care much about Muhammad [pbuh] and took no heed of his teachings. At first, they thought that Muhammad [pbuh] was merely a religious philosopher like Omaiyah bin Abi As-Salt, Quss bin Sa'idah, 'Amr bin Nufail and their ilk who used to philosophize on godship and religious obligations. But this attitude of indifference soon changed into real apprehension. The polytheists of Quraish began to watch Muhammad's movements closely and anxiously for fear of spreading his Call and producing a change in the prevalent mentality. [Fiqh As-Seerah p.76]

The Second Phase: Open Preaching

First Revelation regarding the Preaching

"And warn your tribe (O Muhammad [pbuh]) of near kindred." [Al-Qur'an 26:214].

This was the first verse to be revealed in this concern. It is included in *Sûrah Ash-Shu'arâ* (Chapter 26 – The Poets) which relates the story of Moses [AWS] from his early days of Prophethood going through his migration with the Children of Israel, their escape from the Pharaoh and his folk, and the drowning Pharaoh and his hosts. This Chapter in fact narrates the different stages that Moses [AWS] passed through in his struggle with Pharaoh and the mission of calling his people unto Allâh. Moreover, it includes stories that speak about the terrible end in store for those who belied the Messengers such as the people of Noah, 'Ad, Thamud, Abraham, Lout and *Ahlul-Aikah* (Companions of the Wood). (A group of people who used to worship a tree called *Aikah*)

Chronologically, this Chapter belongs to the middle Makkan period, when the contact of the light of Prophecy with the cultural milieu of pagan Makkah was testing the Makkans in their most arrogant mood. The Message that this Chapter communicates is in brief: “The Truth is insurmountable. When the spirit of Prophecy came to Makkah, it was resisted by the votaries of evil; but Truth, unlike falsehood, is bound to stay, whereas falsehood is surely perishable.”

Calling the Closest Kinspeople

In obedience to Allâh’s Commands, Muhammad [pbuh] rallied his kinsmen of Bani Hashim with a group of Bani Al-Muttalib bin ‘Abd Munaf. The audience counted forty-five men.

On Mount As-Safa

After the Messenger of Allâh [pbuh] became sure of Abu Talib’s commitment to his protection while he called the people unto Allâh, he stood up on Mount As-Safa one day and called out loudly: “O *Sabahah!* [This is an Arabic expression used when one appeals for help or draws the attention of others to some dangers] “Septs of Quraish came to him. He called them to testify to the Oneness of Allâh and believe in his Messengership and the Day of Resurrection.

Shouting the Truth and the Polytheists’ Reaction

The Prophet’s voice kept reverberating in Makkah until the following verse was revealed:

“Therefore proclaim openly (Allâh’s Message — Islamic Monotheism), that which you are commanded, and turn away from *Al-Mushrikûn* (polytheists).” [Al-Qur’an 15:94]

He then commenced discrediting the superstitious practices of idolatry, revealing its worthless reality and utter impotence, and giving concrete proofs that idolatry per se or taking it as the media through which an idolater could come in contact with Allâh, is manifest falsehood.

The Conversion of Hamzah bin ‘Abdul-Muttalib

In a gloomy atmosphere infested with dark clouds of iniquity and tyranny, there shone on the horizon a promising light for the oppressed, i.e. the conversion of Hamzah bin ‘Abdul-Muttalib in Dhul Hijjah, the sixth year of Prophethood.

The Conversion of ‘Umar bin Al-Khattab

Another significant addition to the strength of Islam was the conversion of ‘Umar bin Al-Khattab in Dhul-Hijjah, the sixth year of Prophethood, three days following the conversion of Hamzah.

The Third Phase: Calling unto Islam beyond Makkah

In Shawwal [Tareekh-e-Islam 1/122] (in the last of May or in the beginning of June 619 A.D.), ten years after receiving his mission from his Lord, the Prophet [pbuh] set out towards At-Ta’if, about 60 kilometres from Makkah, in the company of his freed slave Zaid bin Haritha inviting people to Islam. But contrary to his expectations, the general atmosphere was terribly hostile. He approached the family of ‘Umair, who were reckoned amongst the nobility of the town. But, to his disappointment, all of them turned deaf ear to his message and used abusive language as regards the noble cause he had been striving for. Three brothers from the chieftains of Thaqeef — ‘Abd Yaleel, Mas‘ud and Habeeb — sons of ‘Amr bin ‘Umair Ath-Thaqafy met the Prophet [pbuh], who invited them to embrace Islam and worship Allâh, but they impudently jeered at him and refused his invitation. “He is tearing the cloths of Al-Ka’bah; is it true that Allâh has sent you as a Messenger?” said one of them. “Has not Allâh found someone else to entrust him with His Message?” said the second. “I swear by Allâh that I will never have any contact with you. If you are really the Messenger of Allâh, then you are too serious to retort

back; and if you are belying Allâh, then I feel it is imperative not to speak to.” said the third. The Messenger of Allâh [pbuh], finding that they were hopeless cases, stood up and left them saying: “Should you indulge in these practices of yours, never divulge them to me.”

Islam being introduced to Arabian Tribes and Individuals

In Dhul Qa‘dah, the tenth year of Prophethood, i.e. July 619, the Prophet [pbuh], returned to Makkah to resume his activities. The time for pilgrimage to Makkah was approaching so he hastened to introduce people both tribes and individuals to Islam and call upon them to embrace it, just as it was his practice since the fourth year of his Prophethood.

On the authority of Az-Zuhri, of the tribes that Islam was introduced to, we could speak of Banu ‘Amir bin Sa‘sa‘ah, Muharib bin Khasfa, Fazarah, Ghassan, Murrah, Haneefah, Saleem, ‘Abs, Banu Nasr, Banu Al-Buka’, Kindah, Kalb, Al-Harith bin Ka‘b, Udhrah and people of Hadrmut. Islam was not introduced to them in one single year but rather repeatedly from the fourth year till the last pre-migration season of pilgrimage. They however, remained obdurate and none of them responded positively.

Hope inspiring Breezes from the Madinese

It was during the pilgrimage season, in the eleventh year of Prophethood, that the Islamic Call found the righteous seeds through which it would grow up to constitute tall trees whose leaves would foster the new faith and shelter the new vulnerable converts from the blows of injustices and high-handedness of Quraish. It was the Prophet’s wise practice to meet the delegates of the Arabian tribes by night so that the hostile Makkans would not debar him from achieving his objectives.[Tareekh-e-Islam p.129] In the company of his two truthful Companions ‘Ali and Abu Bakr, he had an interesting talk regarding Islamization with Bani Dhuhul, but the latter suspended their conversion.[Mukhtasar Seerat Ar-Rasool p.150] In pursuit of the same objective, the Prophet and his Companions passed by ‘Aqabat Mina where they heard people talking. They went at their heels until they encountered six men from Yathrib, all of whom from Khazraj tribe: As‘ad bin Zurarah, ‘Awf bin Harith, Rafi‘ bin Malik, Qutbah bin ‘Amir, ‘Uqbah bin ‘Amir and Jabir bin ‘Abdullah. The last two being from Aws and the former four from Khazraj.

7. The Quraishy attempts to stop the Prophet (s.a.w.) from his preaching Islam

Three years had passed from the time when the Holy Prophet of Islam was divinely assigned to be a prophet, during which time he did his best to secretly guide those who were capable of being guided onto the path of piety and virtue. Whenever he observed a person who had gone astray, being drowned in the pit of idol worship and moral decay, he tried hard to save him. He entered the scene through the gate of affection and benevolence and with his logical, eloquent speeches urged the people to adopt the monotheistic faith of Islam.

After the early three years of Islam when Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) was in Mecca, he worked tirelessly to call publicly the people of Arabia to Islam. Meanwhile, the tribe of Quraysh who were Mecca’s inhabitants and his kinsmen attempted to stop him from his preaching Islam in every possible way. Now we would like to explain the attempts of Quraish against Islam and Muhammad s.a.w. as mentioned below:

Rejection:

When the prophet (s.a.w.) started preaching Islam especially by an attractive speech on Mount of Safa the Quraysh simply rejected his call. Their rejection of the call to Islam had a major impact on the other Arab tribes, because they enjoyed a position of favor and dominance in Arabian society. Besides, the tribe of Quraysh attended to the sacred House and cared for the needs of those who made pilgrimage to it, providing them with food, water and other services.

The Quraysh Complain To Abu Talib

The Prophet's logical, eloquent speeches greatly impressed many of the people who heard his words. The idol worshippers and the oppressive Quraysh chiefs well realized that if idolatry were abolished, no room would be left for their extortion and oppressive rule. Therefore, they reached the conclusion from their council that they should all go to the house of Abu Talib - a Quraysh chief who was like a father to the Prophet - and ask him to prevent the Prophet from further activities toward propagating his faith by any means he found expedient. For this purpose, they went to Abu Talib, who calmed them down.

Again the chiefs of the Quraysh went to Abu Talib's house. They told him again to stop him from offending the faith of their forefathers, denouncing their idols, thoughts and beliefs because they felt that Abu Talib did not paid any attention to their demands. They also told him if he will not prevent him they will fight against both him and Muhammad.⁴¹

Anti Islamic Propaganda

Having fully perceived that Muhammad [pbuh] could never be desisted from his Call, Quraish, in a desperate attempt to quell the tidal wave of the Call, resorted to other cheap means acting from base motives:

1. Scoffing, degrading, ridiculing, belying and laughter-instigating cheap manners, all of which leveled at the new converts in general, and the person of Muhammad [pbuh] in particular, with the aim of dragging the spirit of despair into their morale, and slackening their ardent zealotry. They used to denounce the Prophet [pbuh] as a man possessed by a jinn, or an insane person,⁴² or a liar practicing witchcraft.⁴³
2. The wicked used to laugh at the righteous in many ways:
 - a. They would inwardly laugh at their Faith, because they felt themselves so superior.
 - b. In public places, when the righteous passed, they used to insult and wink at them,
 - c. In their own houses, they would run them down.
 - d. Whenever and wherever they saw them, they reproached and called them fools who had lost their way. In the Hereafter, all these tricks and falsehoods will be shown for what they are, and the tables will be reversed.
3. Distorting Muhammad's teachings, evoking ambiguities, circulating false propaganda; forging groundless allegations concerning his doctrines, person and character, and going to excess in such a manner in order to screen off any scope of sound contemplation from the public.⁴⁴ The iniquitous went on ceaselessly inculcating in people's ears that the Qur'ân was not a true Revelation.⁴⁵ They

⁴¹ Abu Talib tried to solve the problem peacefully, and after they had left the house, he talked to the Prophet about the matter. Addressing Abu Talib, the Holy Prophet of Islam remarked, 'I swear by Almighty God that even if they put the sun in my right hand and the moon in my left, and in return, demand of me to quit the propagation of Islam... .. I am strongly determined to attain my goal'.

⁴² "And they say: O you (Muhammad [pbuh]) to whom the *Dhikr* (the Qur'ân) has been sent down! Verily, you are a mad man." [Al-Qur'an 15:6]

⁴³ "And they (Arab pagans) wonder that a warner (Prophet Muhammad [pbuh]) has come to them from among themselves! And the disbelievers say: "This (Prophet Muhammad [pbuh]) is a sorcerer, a liar." [Al-Qur'an 38:4].

⁴⁴ "Tales of the ancients, which he (Muhammad [pbuh]) has written down, and they are dictated to him morning and afternoon." [Al-Qur'an 25:5]

⁴⁵ "This (the Qur'ân) is nothing but a lie that he (Muhammad [pbuh]) has invented, and others have helped him at it." [Al-Qur'an 25:4]

also raised another baseless and superficial objection: “*Why does this Messenger (Muhammad [pbuh]) eat food and walk about in the markets (like ourselves)?*” [Al-Qur'an 25:7]

4. Contrasting the Qur'ân with the mythology of the ancients in order to distract people's interests from Allâh's Words. An-Nadr would directly follow the Prophet [pbuh] and narrate to the same audience long tales about those people of Persia. He would then always append his talk with a question cunningly inquiring if he did not outdo Muhammad [pbuh]. [Ibn Hisham 1/299,300,358; Tafheem-ul-Qur'an 4/8,9]. Ibn 'Abbas [R] related that An-Nadr used to purchase songstresses who would through their bodily charms and songs entice away from Islam anyone developing the least attachment to the Prophet [pbuh]; in this regard, Allâh says: “*And of mankind is he who purchases idle talks (i.e. music, singing, etc.) to mislead (men) from the Path of Allâh.*” [Al-Qur'an 31:6] [Tafheem-ul-Qur'an 4/9]

Compromising Proposal

In a fresh attempt to dissuade Muhammad [pbuh] from his principled stand, Quraish invited him to compromise on his teachings and come to terms with their pre-Islamic practices in such a way that he quits some of his religion and the polytheists do the same. They also offered that Muhammad worship their gods for a year, and they worship his Lord for a year, if Muhammad accepts their gods, they also would worship his God⁴⁶. Allâh, the Exalted, was decisive on the spot and revealed the following Chapter:

“*Say: “O Al-Kâfirûn (disbelievers in Allâh, in His Oneness, in His Angels, in His Books, in His Messengers, in the Day of Resurrection, in Al-Qadar, etc.)! I worship not that which you worship, nor will you worship that which I worship. And I shall not worship that which you are worshipping, nor will you worship that which I worship. To you be your religion, and to me my religion (Islamic Monotheism).*” [Al-Qur'an 109] [Ibn Hisham 1/362]

The Quraish Torture the Muslims

The Messenger of Allah continued to call people to Allah and the *Quraysh* despaired of both him and Abu Talib. Their anger descended on those of their fellow tribesmen who had become Muslims and were defenseless. Every clan targeted those who had become Muslims. They began to imprison them and torture them with beatings, hunger and thirst, even leaving them exposed on the sun-baked ground of *Makkah* when the heat was most intense. The *Quraysh* used to torture physically the Muslims, which resulted in the martyrdom of a number of faithful Muslims at the beginning of Islam.

1. Bilal, the slave of Omaiyah bin Khalaf, was severely beaten by his master when the latter came to know of his conversion to Islam. Sometimes a rope was put around his neck and street boys were made to drag him through the streets and even across the hillocks of *Makkah*. At times he was subjected to prolonged deprivation of food and drink; at others he was bound up, made to lie down on the burning sand and under the crushing burden of heavy stones. Similar other measures were resorted to in order to force him to recant. All this proved in vain. He persisted in his belief in the Oneness of Allâh. On one such occasion, Abu Bakr was passing by; moved by pity, he purchased and emancipated him from slavery.⁴⁷
2. Another victim of the highhandedness of Quraish was 'Ammar bin Yasir, a freed slave of Bani Makhzoum. He, along with his mother and father, embraced Islam in its early phase. They were repeatedly made to lie on the burning sand and were beaten severely.⁴⁸ Yasir, the father, died

⁴⁶ Allâh, the All-High says: “They wish that you should compromise (in religion out of courtesy) with them, so they (too) would compromise with you.” [Al-Qur'an 68:9]. On the authority of Ibn Jarir and At-Tabarani, the idolaters offered that Muhammad [pbuh] worship their gods for a year, and they worship his Lord for a year. In another version, they said: “If you accept our gods, we would worship yours.”

⁴⁷ [Ibn Hisham 1/317-318; Rahmat-ul-lil'alameen 1/57]

⁴⁸ The Messenger of Allah passed by them and said reassuringly, ‘Fortitude, family of Yasir! You have the promise of Paradise.’

because of repeated tortures. Sumaiyah, ‘Ammar’s mother was bayoneted to death by Abu Jahl himself, and thus merited the title of the first woman martyr in Islam.

3. The uncle of ‘Uthman bin ‘Affan used to wrap ‘Uthman in a mat of palm leaves, and set fire under him. When Umm Mus‘ab bin ‘Umair heard of her son’s conversion, she put him to starvation and then expelled him from her house. He used to enjoy full luxurious easy life, but in the aftermath of the tortures he sustained, his skin got wizened, and he assumed a horrible physical appearance.⁴⁹
4. One day Abu Bakr boldly invited the idol-worshippers to turn towards Allah and His Messenger. Furious, they fell upon him, beating him and trampling on him. Utbah ibn Rabi‘ah beat him on the face with a pair of sandals until his face was so swollen that his cheeks could not be distinguished from his nose.
5. Abu Fakeeh, Aflah, a freed slave of Bani ‘Abd Ad-Dar was the third of those helpless victims. The oppressors used to fasten his feet with a rope and drag him in the streets of Makkah. [Eijaz At-Tanzil p.53]
6. Khabbab bin Al-Aratt was also an easy victim to similar outrages on every possible occasion. He experienced exemplary torture and maltreatment. The Makkan polytheists used to pull his hair and twist his neck, and made him lie on burning coal with a big rock on his chest to prevent him from escaping. Some Muslims of rank and position were wrapped in the raw skins of camels and thrown away, and others were put in armours and cast on burning sand in the scorching sun of Arabia. [Talqeeh Fuhood Ahl-al-Athar p.60; Rahmat-ul-lil’alameen 1/57]
7. Zanirah, An-Nahdiyah and her daughter, Umm ‘Ubais and many others had their full share of persecution at the hand of the oppressors — ‘Umar bin Al-Khattab included — of course before his conversion to Islam. [Ibn Hisham 1/319]

Attack the Messenger of Allah

The Quraysh were unable to divert these young Muslims from their religion and the Messenger of Allah remained defiant. The Quraysh became so irritated by their helplessness that the more foolish among them started to attack the Messenger of Allah. They even accused him of sorcery, divining and madness. They left no stone unturned in their efforts to harm him.

1. One day the Messenger of Allah appeared in Ka‘bah for *Tawaf* but quickly the Quraish nobles surrounded him and attacked him all together. One of them took hold of his cloak. Abu Bakr (may Allah be pleased with him) stood up weeping and cried, ‘Would you kill a man just for saying: My Lord is Allah?’ When Abu Bakr returned later that day however, they attacked him and tore out some of his hair and dragged him along by his beard.
2. One day while the Prophet was prostrating in the mosque surrounded by some of the Quraysh, ‘Uqbah ibn Abi Mu‘ayt threw the innards of a slaughtered animal on the Prophet’s back but he did not even lift his head. His daughter Fatimah came and removed them, cursing those who had committed the evil deed and the Prophet cursed them as well.
3. On another occasion when the Messenger of Allah went out everyone he met, both free men and slaves, ignored him or tried to hurt him. He returned home and wrapped himself up warmly because he was so distressed by what had happened to him. Allah revealed to him, ‘O you enshrouded, rise up and warn!’ (74: 1)
4. One day a number of Quraysh gave the uterus of a sheep to their servants to throw at the blessed face and head of the Prophet. They obeyed their brutal master, thus making the Prophet rather sad.

⁴⁹ [Rahmat-ul-lil’alameen 1/57; Talqeeh Ahl-al-Athar p.60]

5. Abu Lahab himself and his wife Umm Jamil took the initiative in the new series of persecutions, and started to mete out countless aspects of harmful deeds, hatred and spite against Muhammad [pbuh].⁵⁰
6. Abu Jahl wanted to debar the Prophet [pbuh] from the Noble Sanctuary. One day he shouted to the Prophet uttering abusive language.⁵¹

The Tyrants' Decision to kill the Prophet [pbuh]

Now that all the schemes and conspiracies of Quraish had failed, they resorted to their old practices of persecution and inflicting tortures on the Muslims in a more serious and brutal manner than ever before. They also began to nurse the idea of killing the Prophet [pbuh] .

1. 'Utaibah bin Abi Lahab once approached the Prophet [pbuh] and laid violent hand on him, tore his shirt and spat into his face but his saliva missed the Holy face of the Prophet [pbuh] . The Prophet s.a.w. cursed him and one day he was crushed by the lion and died.⁵²
2. It is also reported that a wretched idolater from Quraish, named 'Uqbah bin 'Abi Mu'ait once trod on the Prophet's neck while he was prostrating himself in prayer until his eyes protruded. [Mukhtasar Seerat Ar-Rasool p.113]
3. Abu Jahl proceeded carrying the big rock to fulfill his wicked intention to kill the Prophet when the Prophet [pbuh] prostrated himself. No sooner had he approached closer to the Prophet [pbuh] than he withdraw pale-faced, shuddering with his hands strained the rock falling off.⁵³
4. 'Uqbah bin Al-Mu'ait came and put his garment around the Prophet's neck and throttled him violently. Abu Bakr came and caught him by his shoulder and pushed him away from the Prophet [pbuh] and said: "Do you want to kill a man just because he says, My Lord is Allâh?"⁵⁴

Quraish's Representative negotiates with the Messenger of Allâh [pbuh]

Shortly after the conversion of the two powerful heroes, Hamzah bin 'Abdul-Muttalib and 'Umar bin Al-Khattab[R] , the clouds of tyranny and oppression started to clear away and the polytheists realized that it was no use meting out torture to the Muslims. They consequently began to direct their campaign to a different course. One day some of the important men of Makkah gathered in the enclosure of Al-Ka'bah, and 'Utbah bin Rabi'a, a chief among them, offered to approach the Prophet [pbuh] and contract a bargain with him whereby they give him whatever worldly wealth he asks for, on condition that he keep silent and no longer proclaim his new faith. The people of Quraish endorsed his proposal and requested him to undertake that task. 'Utbah came closer to Muhammad [pbuh] and addressed him in the following words:

⁵⁰ Starting with flinging stones at him, forcing his two sons to divorce their wives Ruqaiya and Umm Kulthum, the Prophet's daughters [Fi Zilal Al-Qur'an 30/282; Tafheem-ul-Qur'an 6/522], gloating over him on his second son's death calling him 'the man cut off with offspring', and then shadowing his step during the pilgrimage and forums seasons to belie him and entice the Bedouins against him and his Call [At-Tirmidhi]. His wife, Umm Jameel bint Harb, the sister of Abu Sufyan had also her share in this ruthless campaign. She proved that she was not less than her husband in the enmity and hatred she harboured for the Prophet [pbuh] . She used to tie bundles of thorns with ropes of twisted palm-leaf fibre and strew them about in the paths which the Prophet [pbuh] was expected to take, in order to cause him bodily injury. She was a real shrew, bad-tempered with abusive language, highly skilled in the art of hatching intrigues, and enkindling the fire of discord and sedition. She was deservedly stained as '*the carrier of firewood*' in the Noble Qur'an. On receiving this news, she directly proceeded to the Mosque with a handful of pebbles to hurl at the Prophet [pbuh]

⁵¹ It happened once that the Prophet [pbuh] was praying within the precinct of the Sacred House, when Abu Jahl proceeded threateningly and uttering abusive language. The Prophet [pbuh] chided him severely to which Abu Jahl answered back defiantly claiming that he was the mightiest in Makkah; Allâh then revealed: "Then, let him call upon his council (of helpers)." [Al-Qur'an 96:17] In another version of the same incident, the Prophet [pbuh] took Abu Jahl by his neck, rocked him severely saying: "Woe to you [O man (disbeliever)]! And then (again) woe to you! Again, woe to you [O man (disbeliever)]! And then (again) woe to you!" [Al-Qur'an 75:34, 35].

⁵² [Tafheem-ul-Qur'an 6/522; Quoted from Al-Isti'ab, Al-Isaba, Dala'il An-Nubuwwah, etc]

⁵³ Thereupon, the people watching hurried forward asking him what the matter was. He replied: "When I approached, a male-camel unusual in figure with fearful canines intercepted and almost devoured me." Ibn Ishaq reported that the Prophet [pbuh], in the context of his comment on the incident, said "It was Gabriel[AWS] , if Abu Jahl had approached closer, he would have killed him.[Ibn Hisham 1/298]"

⁵⁴ [Bukhari 1/544]

We have seen no other man of Arabia, who has brought so great a calamity to a nation, as you have done. You have outraged our gods and religion and taxed our forefathers and wise men with impiety and error and created strife amongst us. You have left no stone unturned to estrange the relations with us. If you are doing all this with a view to getting wealth, we will join together to give you greater riches than any Quraishite has possessed. If ambition moves you, we will make you our chief. If you desire kingship we will readily offer you that. If you are under the power of an evil spirit which seems to haunt and dominate you so that you cannot shake off its yoke, then we shall call in skilful physicians to cure you.

The Messenger of Allâh [pbuh] recited some parts of Qur'an and 'Utbaah astonished and influenced by the Qur'aic verses. He then hurriedly returned to his compatriots and informed them of what he had heard. [Ibn Hisham 1/293,294] [Tafseer Ibn Kathir 6/159-161]

General Social Boycott

The Quraysh had started a fierce economic struggle against the Prophet and his followers. One of the inhumane weapons they used against the Muslims was economic pressure and boycott of any sort of transactions with the Muslims. Prohibiting of marriage with Muslims, cutting off all relations with them from the Quraysh, and accusing the Holy Prophet of Islam of witchcraft, telling lies, and the like were psychological tactics meant to break down the resistance and perseverance of the first Muslims. Abu Talib wisely and quietly took stock of the situation and decided to withdraw to a valley on the eastern outskirts of Makkah. Banu Hashim and Banu Al-Muttalib, who followed suit, were thus confined within a narrow pass (Shi'b of Abu Talib), from the beginning of Muharram, the seventh year of Muhammad's mission till the tenth year, viz., a period of three years. It was a stifling siege. In their isolation, however, they suffered all kinds of privations; often they could not find enough food to satisfy their hunger. It was not possible either for Muhammad or the Muslims to mix with other people or to talk to them except during the holy months, when the Arabs would come to Makkah on pilgrimage and all hostilities would cease.

8. Migration to Abyssinia

Background:

The series of persecutions started late in the fourth year of Prophethood, slowly at first, but steadily accelerated and worsened day by day and month by month until the situation got so extremely grave and no longer tolerable in the middle of the fifth year, that the Muslims began to seriously think of feasible ways liable to avert the painful tortures meted out to them. The Prophet [pbuh] had already known that Ashamah Negus, king of Abyssinia (Ethiopia), was a fair ruler who would not wrong any of his subordinates, so he permitted some of his followers to seek asylum there in Abyssinia (Ethiopia).

Migration:

In Rajab of the fifth year of Prophethood, a group of twelve men and four women left for Abyssinia (Ethiopia). Among the emigrants were 'Uthman bin 'Affan and his wife Ruqaiyah (the daughter of the Prophet [pbuh]). With respect to these two emigrants, the Prophet [pbuh] said:

"They are the first people to migrate in the cause of Allâh after Abraham and Lot [AWS]."

They sneaked out of Makkah under the heavy curtain of a dark night and headed for the sea where two boats happened to be sailing for Abyssinia (Ethiopia), their destination. News of their intended departure reached the ears of Quraish, so some men were dispatched in their pursuit, but the believers had already left Shuaibah Port towards their secure haven where they were received warmly and accorded due hospitality.

Returning and Second time migration

News of this incident was misreported to the Muslim emigrants in Abyssinia (Ethiopia). They were informed that the whole of Quraish had embraced Islam so they made their way back home. They arrived in Makkah in Shawwal of the same year. When they were only an hour's travel from Makkah, the reality of the situation was discovered. Some of them returned to Abyssinia (Ethiopia), others sneaked secretly into the city or went in publicly but under the tutelage of a local notable.⁵⁵

However, due to the news that transpired to the Makkans about the good hospitality and warm welcome that the Muslims were accorded in Abyssinia (Ethiopia), the polytheists got terribly indignant and started to mete out severer and more horrible maltreatment and tortures to the Muslims. Thereupon the Messenger of Allâh [pbuh] deemed it imperative to permit the helpless creatures to seek refuge in Abyssinia (Ethiopia) for the second time. Migration this time was not as easy as it was the previous time, for Quraish was on the alert to the least suspicious moves of the Muslims. In due course, however, the Muslims managed their affairs too fast for the Quraishites to thwart their attempt of escape. The group of emigrants this time comprised eighty three men and nineteen or, in some versions, eighteen women. Whether or not 'Ammar was included is still a matter of doubt.⁵⁶ Rafiq Zakaria noted:

Unable to bear the hardships, a group of 15 Muslims, on the advice of Muhammad, migrated to Axum (in 613) where a benign Christian ruler, king Negus gave the shelter.

Two years after (in 615) the first migration, a second group of about a hundred of the persecuted Muslims led by Jafar, brother of Ali, left for Axum.⁵⁷

Some reports noted migrations were made to Axum in three batches.

Quraish Delegation

Quraish could not tolerate the prospect of a secure haven available for the Muslims in Abyssinia (Ethiopia), so they dispatched two staunch envoys to demand their extradition. They were 'Amr bin Al-'As and 'Abdullah bin Abi Rabi'a — before embracing Islam. They had taken with them valuable gifts to the king and his clergy, and had been able to win some of the courtiers over to their side. The pagan envoys claimed that the Muslim refugees should be expelled from Abyssinia (Ethiopia) and made over to them, on the ground that they had abandoned the religion of their forefathers, and their leader was preaching a religion different from theirs and from that of the king.

The king summoned (called) the Muslims to the court and asked them to explain the teachings of their religion. The Muslim emigrants had decided to tell the whole truth whatever the consequences were. Ja'far bin Abi Talib stood up and addressed the king about some characteristics of Islam and Polytheism. The king was very much impressed by these words and asked the Muslims to recite some of Allâh's Revelation. Ja'far recited the opening verses of *Sûrah Maryam* (Chapter 19 — Mary) wherein is told the story of the birth of both John and Jesus Christ, down to the account of Mary having been fed with the food miraculously. Thereupon the king, along with the bishops of his realm, was moved to tears that rolled down his cheeks and even wet his beard. The king permitted the Muslims to live freely.

On the morrow, the two envoys again went to the king and said that Muhammad [pbuh] and his followers blasphemed Jesus Christ. Again the Muslims were summoned and asked what they thought

⁵⁵ Tafheem-ul-Qur'an 5/188; Za'd Al-Ma'ad 1/24; Ibn Hisham 1/364; Rahmat-ul-lil'alameen 1/61

⁵⁶ Ibid.

⁵⁷ Rafiq Zakaria, 1991, *Muhammad and The Quran*, New Delhi: [Penguin Books](#), pp. 403-4. [ISBN 0-14-014423-4](#)

of Jesus. Ja'far again stood up and clarified Islamic statement about Jesus. The kind convinced and sent the Quraish envoys away. The Muslims lived in Abyssinia (Ethiopia) unmolested for a number of years till they returned to Madinah.⁵⁸

Lessons to be Learned:

1. If the Daa'iyah finds out that his group is in deadly danger or that their beliefs are exposed to fitnah (trail), then he must prepare for them a place where they can be safe from the enmity of the followers of falsehood. This is not contrary to the daa'iyah's obligation to be prepared to sacrifice himself. For if the daa'iyahs are few, the followers of falsehood could finish them off with one blow and put an end to their call. If they are in a safe place, this guarantees that the da'wah will continue to spread.
2. Da'iyah (caller to Islam) can migrate to a secured place of the world although it would be a non-Muslim country.
3. Prophet's permission of migration to Abyssinia indicates the relationship between religious people, despite the differences in their religious, is stronger than their ties to ido-worshippers and atheists. For the divinely-revealed religions – in their true and original forms – share the same social goals, as well as belief in Allah and His Prophets and the Last Day. This is what makes the ties among them stronger than any ties of kinship, blood or nationality with atheists, idol worshippers and those who disbelieve in the laws of Allah.
4. The followers of falsehood will give in easily to the people of truth. Every time they fail in one means of resisting and defeating the call to truth, they will come up with something else. This is how it will continue until truth attains its final victory and falsehood is finally defeated.
5. It is duty for Du'at (the Callers to Islam) to defend themselves strongly with view to expressing the truth even before the king.

9. The Economic and Social Boycott of the Banu Hashim

Background

The new and welcome changes notwithstanding, Abu Talib still had a deep sensation of fear over his nephew. He deliberated on the previous series of incidents including the barter affair of 'Amarah bin Al-Waleed, Abu Jahl's rock, 'Uqbah's attempt to choke the Prophet [pbuh] , and finally 'Umar's (before conversion) intention to kill Muhammad [pbuh]. The kuffars of Quraish often demanded that Banu Hashim hand over Prophet Mohamed (saws) to them, or at least relieve him of the protection of this tribe. The wise man understood that all of these unequivocally smacked of a serious plot being hatched to disregard his status as a custodian of the Prophet [pbuh], and kill the latter publicly. In the event of such a thing, Abu Talib deeply believed, neither 'Umar nor Hamzah would be of any avail, socially powerful though they were. [Ibn Hisham 1/269; Mukhtasar Seerat Ar-Rasool p.106]

Abu Talib was right. The polytheists had laid a carefully-studied plan to kill the Prophet [pbuh] , and banded together to put their plan into effect. He, therefore, assembled his kinsfolk of Bani Hashim and Bani Al-Muttalib, sons of 'Abd Munaf and exhorted them to immunize and defend his nephew. All of them, whether believers or disbelievers, responded positively except his brother Abu Lahab, who sided with the idolaters.

⁵⁸ Ibn Hisham 1/334-338

A few days before the beginning of the year 7, the leaders of the various clans of Quraysh met in a solemn conclave in the "town hall" of Makkah, and there, by consensus, they drafted and signed a document which stipulated that unless the clan of Banu Hashim surrendered Muhammad to them, it would be subjected to an economic and social boycott. They pledged themselves not to buy anything from, nor to sell anything to, the members of the Banu Hashim, and they placed intermarriage with them under proscription. Social relations, visits and even verbal contacts with Muhammad [pbuh] and his supporters would discontinue. The document was suspended in Al Ka'ba.

Life of Banu Hashim and Abdul Muttalib in Shi'ab Abi Talib

Abu Talib wisely and quietly took stock of the situation and decided to withdraw to a valley on the eastern outskirts of Makkah. Banu Hashim and Banu Al-Muttalib, who followed suit, were thus confined within a narrow pass (Shi'b of Abu Talib), from the beginning of Muharram, the seventh year of Muhammad's mission till the tenth year, viz., a period of three years.

It was a stifling siege. The supply of food was almost stopped and the people in confinement faced great hardships. The idolaters used to buy whatever food commodities entered Makkah lest they should leak to the people in Ash-Shi'b, who were so overstrained that they had to eat leaves of trees and skins of animals. Cries of little children suffering from hunger used to be heard clearly. Nothing to eat reached them except, on few occasions, some meager (insufficient) quantities of food were smuggled by some compassionate Makkans. During 'the prohibited months' — when hostilities traditionally ceased, they would leave their confinement and buy food coming from outside Makkah. Even then, the food stuff was unjustly overpriced so that their financial situation would fall short of finding access to it.

Hakeem bin Hizam was once on his way to smuggle some wheat to his aunt Khadijah [R]Ç when Abu Jahl intercepted and wanted to debar him. Only when Al-Bukhtari intervened, did Hakeem manage to reach his destination. Abu Talib was so much concerned about the personal safety of his nephew. Whenever people retired to sleep, he would ask the Prophet [pbuh] to lie in his place, but when all the others fell asleep, he would order him to change his place and take another, all of which in an attempt to trick a potential assassin.

Despite all odds, Muhammad [pbuh] persisted in his line and his determination and courage never weakened. He continued to go to Al-Ka'bah and to pray publicly. He used every opportunity to preach to outsiders who visited Makkah for business or on pilgrimage during the sacred months and special seasons of assemblies.

The Annuling of the Boycott

This situation ultimately created dissension amongst the various Makkan factions, who were tied with the besieged people by blood relations. After three years of blockade and in Muharram, the tenth year of Muhammad's mission, the pact was broken. Hisham bin 'Amr, who used to smuggle some food to Bani Hashim secretly at night, went to see Zuhair bin Abi Omaiyah Al-Makhzoumy and reproached him for resigning to that intolerable treatment meted out to his uncles in exile. The latter pleaded impotence (helplessness), but agreed to work with Hisham and form a pressure group that would secure the extrication of the exiles. On the ground of motivation by uterine (same mother but different fathers) relations, there emerged a group of five people who set out to abrogate the pact and declare all relevant clauses null and void. They were Hisham bin 'Amr, Zuhair bin Abi Omaiyah, Al-Mut'im bin

‘Adi, Abu Al-Bukhtari and Zam‘a bin Al-Aswad. They decided to meet in their assembly place and start their self-charged mission from the very precinct of the Sacred House. Zuhair, after circumambulating seven times, along with his colleagues approached the hosts of people there and rebuked them for indulging in the amenities of life whereas their kith and kin of Bani Hashim were perishing on account of starvation and economic boycott. They swore they would never relent until the parchment of boycott was torn to piece and the pact broken at once. Abu Jahl, standing nearby, retorted that it would never be torn. Zam‘a was infuriated and accused Abu Jahl of telling lies, adding that the pact was established and the parchment was written without seeking their approval. Al-Bukhtari intervened and backed Zam‘a. Al-Mut‘im bin ‘Adi and Hisham bin ‘Amr attested to the truthfulness of their two companions. Abu Jahl, with a cunning attempt to liquidate the hot argument that was running counter to his malicious goals, answered that the issue had already been resolved sometime and somewhere before.

Abu Talib meanwhile was sitting in a corner of the Mosque. He came to communicate to them that a Revelation had been sent to his nephew, the Prophet [pbuh] to the effect that ants had eaten away all their proclamation that smacked of injustice and aggression except those parts that bore the Name of Allâh. He contended that he would be ready to give Muhammad [pbuh] up to them if his words proved untrue, otherwise, they would have to recant and repeal their boycott. The Makkans agreed to the soundness of his proposition. Al-Mut‘im went to see the parchment and there he did discover that it was eaten away by ants and nothing was left save the part bearing (in the Name of Allâh).

The proclamation was thus abrogated, and Muhammad [pbuh] and the other people were permitted to leave Ash-Sh‘ib and return home. In the context of this trial to which the Muslims were subjected, the polytheists had a golden opportunity to experience a striking sign of Muhammad’s Prophethood (the white ants eating away the parchment) but to their miserable lot they desisted and augmented in disbelief:

"But if they see a Sign, they turn away, and say ‘This is continuous magic.’" [Al-Qur’an 54:2]
[Bukhari (in several chapters); Za’d Al-Ma‘ad 2/46; Ibn Hisham 1/350]

10. The Year of Grief

The 10th year of Prophethood is called as the year of grief (‘Amul Huzn). Rapid succession of misfortunes, led the Prophet [pbuh] to call that period, ‘the year of grief and mourning’, for three great incidents:

1. Death of Abu Talib
2. Death of Khadiza
3. Harassment in Ta’if

Abu Talib’s Death

In Rajab[Tareekh Al-Islam 1/120], the tenth year of the Prophethood, Abu Talib fell ill and passed away, six months after leaving the confinement at Ash-Sh‘ib. In another version, Abu Talib breathed his last in Ramadan, three days prior to the death of Khadijah [R]. On the authority of Al-Musaiyab, when Abu Talib was on the death bed, the Prophet [pbuh] entered the room where he saw Abu Jahl and ‘Abdullah bin Abi Omaiyah. He requested repeatedly his uncle to accept Islam. On the contrary Abu Jahl and others reminded him not abandon the religion of ‘Abdul-Muttalib. Finally ‘Abu Talib stuck to the religion of ‘Abdul-Muttalib. In this regard Allah said: *"Verily! You (O Muhammad [pbuh]) guide not whom you like."* [Al-Qur'an 28:56] [Bukhari 1/548]

It goes without saying that Abu Talib was very much attached to Muhammad [pbuh] . For forty years, Abu Talib had been the faithful friend — the prop of his childhood, the guardian of his youth and in later life a very tower of defense. The sacrifices to which Abu Talib exposed himself and his family for the sake of his nephew, while yet incredulous of his mission, stamp his character as singularly noble and unselfish. The Prophet [pbuh] did his best to persuade his octogenarian uncle to make profession of the true faith, but he remained obdurate and stuck to the paganism of his forefathers, and thus could not achieve complete success.

Khadijah passes away to the Mercy of Allâh

Only two months after the death of his uncle, did the Messenger of Allâh [pbuh] experience another great personal loss viz., the Mother of believers, his wife Khadijah passed away in Ramadan of the tenth year of his Prophethood, when she was sixty-five years old, and he was fifty [Talqeeh Fuhood Ahl-al-Athar p.7; Rahmat-ul-lil'alameen 2/164].

Khadijah was in fact a blessing of Allâh for the Prophet [pbuh] . She, for twenty-five years, shared with him the toils and trials of life, especially in the first ten years of his ministry of Prophethood. He deeply mourned over her death, and once he replied in an honest burst of tender emotions:

"She believed in me when none else did. She embraced Islam when people disbelieved me. And she helped and comforted me in her person and wealth when there was none else to lend me a helping hand. I had children from her only." [Musnad Imam Ahmad 6/118]

One day Gabriel informed Muhammad Allah's greetings to Khadija a glad tidings of a palace of jewels in Paradise. [Bukhari 1/539]

Effect of the death of ‘Abu Talib and Khadija

These two painful events took place within a short lapse of time and added a lot to his grief and suffering. The Makkans now openly declared their campaign of torture and oppression.

His Companions were on equal footing subjected to unspeakable torture and unbearable oppression to such an extent that his closest friend, Abu Bakr, to escape pressure, fled out of Makkah and wanted to leave for Abyssinia (Ethiopia) if it were not for Ibn Ad-Daghanah who met him at Bark Al-Ghamad and managed to dissuade him from completing his journey of escape and brought him back under his protection. [Bukhari 1/552; Ibn Hisham 1/372]

The death of Abu Talib rendered the Prophet [pbuh] vulnerable (helpless), and the polytheists availed them of that opportunity to give free rein to their hatred and highhandedness and to translate them in terms of oppression and physical tortures. Once an insolent Quraishite intercepted him and sprinkled sand on his head. When he arrived home, a daughter of his washed the sand away and wept. "Do not weep, my daughter. Allâh will verily protect your father." The Prophet [pbuh] said. [Ibn Hisham 1/416]

Harassment in Ta'if / Journey to Ta'if

The Prophet [pbuh] lost all hope of bringing them back to the right path after the death of ‘Abu Talib and Khadija, so he set out for Al-Ta'if seeking a supportive atmosphere. But there too, he was

disappointed and he sustained unbearable tortures and maltreatment that far outweighed his miserable situation in his native town.

In Shawwal [Tareekh-e-Islam 1/122] (in the last of May or in the beginning of June 619 A.D.), ten years after receiving his mission from his Lord, the Prophet [pbuh] set out towards At-Ta'if, about 60 kilometres from Makkah, in the company of his freed slave Zaid bin Haritha inviting people to Islam. But contrary to his expectations, the general atmosphere was terribly hostile. All of them turned deaf ear to his message and used abusive language as regards the noble cause he had been striving for and they impudently jeered at him and refused his invitation. One of them said: "Has not Allâh found someone else to entrust him with His Message?" said the second. "I swear by Allâh that I will never have any contact with you. If you are really the Messenger of Allâh, then you are too serious to retort back; and if you are belying Allâh, then I feel it is imperative not to speak to." said the third. The Messenger of Allâh [pbuh], finding that they were hopeless cases, stood up and left them saying: "Should you indulge (treat) in these practices of yours, never divulge them to me."

For ten days he stayed there delivering his message to several people, one after another, but all to no purpose. Stirred up to hasten the departure of the unwelcome visitor, the people hooted him through the alley-ways, pelted him with stones and obliged him to flee from the city pursued by a relentless rabble. Blood flowed down both his legs; and Zaid, endeavoring to shield him, was wounded in the head. The mob did not desist until they had chased him two or three miles across the sandy plains to the foot of the surrounding hills. There, wearied and exhausted, he took refuge in one of the numerous orchards, and rested against the wall of a vineyard. At a time when the whole world seemed to have turned against him, Muhammad [pbuh] turned to his Lord and betook himself to prayer and the following touching words are still preserved as those through which his oppressed soul gave vent to its distress. He was weary and wounded but confident of the help of his Lord:

"O Allâh! To You alone I make complaint of my helplessness, the paucity (scarcity) of my resources and my insignificance before mankind. You are the most Merciful of the mercifuls. You are the Lord of the helpless and the weak, O Lord of mine! Into whose hands would You abandon me: into the hands of an unsympathetic distant relative who would sullenly frown at me, or to the enemy who has been given control over my affairs? But if Your wrath does not fall on me, there is nothing for me to worry about."

"I seek protection in the light of Your Countenance, which illuminates the heavens and dispels darkness, and which controls all affairs in this world as well as in the Hereafter. May it never be that I should incur Your wrath, or that You should be wrathful to me. And there is no power nor resource, but Yours alone."

Seeing him in this helpless situation, Rabi'a's two sons, wealthy Makkans, were moved on grounds of kinship and compassion, and sent to him one of their Christian servants with a tray of grapes. The Prophet [pbuh] accepted the fruit with pious invocation: "In the Name of the Allâh." The Christian servant 'Addas was greatly impressed by these words. After some talks he paid homage to Muhammad [pbuh] and kissed his hands.

Heart-broken and depressed, Muhammad [pbuh] set out on the way back to Makkah. When he reached Qarn Al-Manazil, Allâh, the Almighty sent him Gabriel together with the angel of mountains. The latter asked the Prophet [pbuh] for permission to bury Makkah between Al-Akhshabain —Abu Qubais and Qu'ayqa'an mountains, but he refused to punish them. Full narration of this event was given by 'Aishah [R] (the

Prophet's spouse). She said: "I asked the Prophet [pbuh] if he had ever experienced a worse day than Uhud. He answered that he had suffered a lot from those people (the idolaters) but the most painful was on the day of 'Aqabah. I went seeking support from Ibn 'Abd Yalil bin 'Abd Kalal, but he spurned (rejected) me. I set out wearied and grieved heedless of anything around me until I suddenly realized I was in Qarn Ath-Tha'alib, called Qarn Al-Manazil. There, I looked up and saw a cloud casting its shade on me, and Gabriel addressing me: Allâh has heard your people's words and sent you the angel of mountains to your aid. The latter called and gave me his greetings and asked for my permission to bury Makkah between Al-Akhshabain, the two mountains flanking Makkah. I said in reply that I would rather have someone from their loins who will worship Allâh, the All-Mighty with no associate." A concise meaningful answer fully indicative of the Prophet's matchless character and the fathomless magnanimous manners. [Bukhari 1/458; Muslim 2/109]

The Messenger of Allâh [pbuh] then came back to wakefulness and his heart was set at rest in the light of that invisible Divinely provided aid. He proceeded to Wadi Nakhlah where he stayed for a few days.

During his stay there, Allâh sent him a company of *jinns* who listened to him reciting the Noble Qur'ân:

"And (remember) when We sent towards you (Muhammad [pbuh]) Nafran (three to ten persons) of the jinns, (quietly) listening to the Qur'ân... He (Allâh) will forgive you of your sins, and will save you from a painful torment (i.e. Hell-fire)." [Al-Qur'an 46:29-31]

The same incident is referred to in *Sûrah Al-Jinn*: "Say (O Muhammad [pbuh]): "It has been revealed to me that a group (from three to ten in number) of jinns listened (to this Qur'ân). They said: 'Verily! We have heard a wonderful Recital (this Qur'ân)! It guides to the Right Path, and we have believed therein, and we shall never join (in worship) anything with our Lord (Allâh).'" [Al-Qur'an 72:1,2] ... Till the end of the 15th verse.

Given this support and auspicious start, depression, dismay and sadness that used to beset him since he was driven out of At-Ta'if, he turned his face towards Makkah with fresh determination to resume his earlier plan to expose people to Islam and communicate his Message in a great spirit of zeal and matchless enthusiasm.

11. Isra' and Mi'raj

The year 619 A.D. was known as the "Year of Sadness" in Islamic history. The Muslim community was under constant persecution, and in that year the Prophet Muhammad's beloved wife Khadeeja and his uncle Abu Talib both died. Without Abu Talib's protection, the Muslim community experienced ever-increasing harassment in Makkah. The Prophet Muhammad visited the nearby city of Taif to preach the Oneness of God and seek asylum from the Meccan oppressors; he was eventually mocked and run out of town.

In the midst of this adversity, the Prophet Muhammad had a comforting experience, which is now known as *Isra' and Mi'raj* (the Night Visit and Ascension). During the month of Rajab, the Prophet Muhammad made a night-time trip to the city of Jerusalem (*isra'*), visited the Al-Aqsa Mosque, and from there was raised up into heaven (*mi'raj*).

Date of Isra' and Mi'raj

As for its exact date, it is still controversial and no common consent has been reached.

1. Some scholars, including Imam At-Tabari, are of the opinion that the Night Journey occurred in the same year the Prophet (peace and blessings be upon him) received the first revelation.
2. Imams An-Nawawi and Al-Qurtubi prefer the opinion that it occurred five years after the Prophet's mission.

3. Another opinion sets Rajab 27, 10 years after the Prophet embarked on his great mission as the exact date of the event.
4. However, the majority of jurists is in favor of a date between 16-12 months prior to migration to Madinah. The following is a epitome of the details of that miraculous event narrated on the authority of Ibn Al-Qayyim.[Za'd Al-Ma'ad 2/49; Tareekh-e-Islam 1/124; Rahmat-al-lil'alameen 1/76]

Story of Isra' and Mi'raj

The scholars of *Hadith* reported the details of the Night of *Al-Israa'*. Here Mubarakpuri gave a summary of the Night's events:

The Prophet (peace and blessings be upon him) was carried in body from the Sacred Mosque in Makkah to the Al-Aqsa Mosque in Jerusalem on a mount called Al-Buraq in the company of Angel Gabriel. There Prophet Muhammad led all the other prophets in prayer.

After that Gabriel took him to the heavens. When they reached the first heaven Gabriel asked the guardian angel to open the first heaven's door. It was opened and Prophet Muhammad saw Adam, the progenitor of humankind. The Prophet saluted him. Adam welcomed him and expressed his faith in Muhammad's prophethood. The Prophet saw on the right side of Adam the souls of those who will be happy in the hereafter and saw the souls of the doomed ones on his left.

Gabriel then ascended with the Prophet (peace and blessings be upon him) to the second heaven and asked for opening the gate. There the Prophet saw and saluted Prophets Yahya (John) and `Isa (Jesus). They returned the salutation, welcomed him, and expressed their faith in his Prophethood.

The same happened in each heaven: In the third heaven, the Prophet saw Prophet Yusuf (Joseph); in the fourth, Prophet Idris (Enoch); in the fifth, Prophet Harun (Aaron); in the sixth, Prophet Musa (Moses); and in the seventh, Prophet Ibrahim (Abraham),(peace and blessings be upon them all).

When Prophet Muhammad left Prophet Musa (peace and blessings be upon both of them) in the sixth heaven, Prophet Musa began to weep. Asked about the reason, he answered that though Muhammad was sent after him as a messenger, those who will enter Paradise from Muhammad's nation are greater in number than those from Musa's nation.

The Prophet then was carried to *Sidrat Al-Muntaha* (Arabic for "the remotest Lote-tree") and was shown *Al-Bait Al-Ma'mur* (Arabic for "the much-frequented house") which is attended daily by 70,000 angels; the angels who attend it never leave it until the Day of Resurrection.

He was then presented to the Divine Presence getting at the closest possible nearness. There Almighty Allah ordained 50 daily prayers for him.

On his way back, he told Prophet Musa that his followers had been enjoined to pray 50 times a day. Prophet Musa advised him to ask Allah to reduce the number because the Muslim *Ummah* would not bear performing such a number of prayers. The Prophet turned to Gabriel as if asking his counsel. Gabriel nodded, "Yes, if you desire," and ascended with him to Almighty Allah. Then Almighty Allah made a reduction of 10 prayers. The Prophet then descended and reported that to Musa, who again urged him to request a further reduction.

The Prophet once more begged Allah to reduce the number further. He went again and again to Almighty Allah at the suggestion of Musa till the prayers were reduced to five only. Again, Musa

asked him to implore for more reduction, but the Prophet said, "I feel embarrassed (of repeatedly asking my Lord to reduce the number of daily prayers.) I accept and resign to His Will." When the Prophet went farther, a caller was heard saying: "I have imposed My (Allah's) ordinance and alleviated the burden of My servants."

Significant suggestive incidents featured the ‘Night Journey’

Some significant suggestive incidents featured the ‘Night Journey’ of the Prophet, of which we could mention:

1. The Prophet’s breast was cleft by Gabriel, his heart extracted and washed with the water of Zamzam —a sacred spring in Makkah.
2. In the same context, there were brought to him two gold vessels. There was milk in one, while the other was full of wine. He was asked to choose either of them, so he selected the vessel containing milk and drank it. He (the angel) said: "You have been guided on *Al-Fitrah* or you have attained *Al-Fitrah*. Had you selected wine, your nation would have been misled." [It is a symbolic way of saying that good and evil in the form of milk and wine were brought before the Prophet and he instinctively made a choice for the good. It is very difficult to render the Arabic term ‘*Fitrah*’ into English. It denotes the original constitution or disposition, with which a child comes into this world, as contrasted with qualities or inclinations acquired during life; besides it refers to the spiritual inclination inherent in man in his unspoilt state].
3. The Prophet [pbuh] told that he saw two manifest rivers, — the Nile and the Euphrates — and two hidden ones. It appears that the two manifest rivers, the Nile and the Euphrates, symbolically describe the area in whose fertile valleys, Muhammad’s Message will settle, and the people whereof will always remain the adherent bearers of Islam that will be passed on from generation to another. They can by no means suggest that they well up from the Garden.
4. He had the opportunity to see Malik, the guardian of Hell, with a cheerless frowning face. Therein, he saw the Hell dwellers, of whom were those who unjustly eat up the property of the orphans. They have flews similar to those of camels, swallowing red-hot stones and then issuing out of their backs. There were also the people who take usury with bellies too big to be able to move around; they are trodden by the people of Pharaoh when these are admitted into Hell. In the same abode, he saw the adulterers offered tasty fatty meat and rotten smelly one but they make option for the latter. The licentious women were also there hanging from their breasts.
5. The ‘Night Journey’ raised a good deal of stir among the people and the skeptical audience plied Muhammad with all sorts of questions. He told them that he saw the camels of Makkan merchants to and fro. He also guided them to some of their animals that went astray. He informed them that he had drunk some of their water while they were fast asleep and left the container covered.

The disbelievers found it a suitable opportunity to jeer at the Muslims and their creed. They pestered the Prophet with questions as to the description of the Mosque at Jerusalem, where he had never gone before, and to their astonishment, the Prophet's replies furnished the most accurate information about it. However, this increased in them nothing but flight from Islam, and they accepted nothing but disbelief.

For true Muslims, however, there was nothing unusual about the Night Journey. Almighty Allah, Who is powerful enough to have created the heavens and the earth, is surely powerful enough to take His Messenger beyond the heavens and show him firsthand those signs of His that are inaccessible to people otherwise.

This believing attitude was epitomized by Abu Bakr (may Allah be pleased with him) whom the disbelievers challenged on account of this event to believe what the Prophet said, and he readily said, "Yes, I do verify it." It is reported that this answer is what earned him the famous title of As-Siddiq (Arabic for "the verifier of the truth").

Lessons of Al-Israa' & Mi'raj

Undoubtedly the occasion of Al-Israa' and Al-Mi'raj is a unique and very important occasion. Every year, when its time draws near we need to be reminded about it. Not only that, but we also need to keep in touch with our important historical events so as to derive fruitful lessons from them while moving forward.

1. From *Al-Israa'* and *Al-Mi'raj* we should learn about the brotherhood that exists among the prophets and the wonderful role and advice given by Prophet Musa to our beloved Prophet on the night of *Al-Mi'raj*. Prophet Musa advised Prophet Muhammad (peace and blessings be upon him) to seek a review and the mercy of Allah in reducing the number of obligatory Prayers which was, at the beginning, 50 Prayers per day and then it was reduced to five daily Prayers with the reward of 50 Prayers.
2. During the Prophet's journey, the Prophet was shown Heaven and Hell and this strengthened his belief and commitment to call upon his *Ummah* to do deeds that lead to Heaven and avoid all deeds that lead to Hell.
3. It is hoped that *Al-Israa'* and *Al-Mi'raj* become an occasion to remind Muslims all over the world about the oppression and injustice that is going on against our beloved brothers and sisters in Palestine and elsewhere throughout the world.
4. Furthermore, it should be taken as an occasion to remind all Muslims about the real condition of *Al-Masjid Al-Aqsa* which is now under unjust occupation and is about to be demolished, may Allah forbid! This journey shall teach us the necessity of doing our best to assist our fellow Muslims who are living under occupation and destruction and daily mass murder and humiliation.
5. It is a symbol of the high ambition that every Muslim should have, and how he should rise above the whims and desires of this world, and be distinct from all others in his high status, lofty goals and continual pursuit of the highest example.
6. It also indicates that it is possible to explore space and move beyond the gravitational pull of the earth. During the *Isra'* and *Mi'raj*, our Messenger was the first space and returning safely to earth is something that is possible. It happened to the Messenger of Allah by means of a miracle at his time, but it can happen to people now by means of science.
7. The fact that prayer was enjoined on the night of the *Isra'* and *Mi'raj* points to the reason why prayer is enjoined. It is as if Allah is saying to His believing slaves: If the ascent of your Messenger's body and soul into the heavens was a miracle, then you can ascend five times every day as your hearts and souls ascend to Me, so you may ascend spiritually which will enable you to rise above your whims and desires, and bear witness to My greatness, Might and Oneness, which will motivate you to seek control of the earth, not by means of enslaving, force and conquest, but by means of goodness and noble character, by means of purification and sublime characteristics, by means of prayer.
8. The *Al-Masjid Al-Aqsa* issue is not a Palestinian issue nor is it an Arab issue but it is an Islamic issue and so all Muslims have equal rights in determining its fate. The occasion of *Al-Israa'* and *Al-Mi'raj* should be utilized to remind us to exert all possible efforts to liberate *Al-Aqsa* Mosque and to end occupation and injustice against helpless Palestinians.
9. As Muslims, we should take this opportunity to pray for our fellow Muslims around the globe who are suffering from atrocities and pain. All Muslims should remember that the liberation of Al-

Masjid Al-Aqsa is not an obligation upon the Palestinians alone but upon every single able-bodied Muslim. Each of us must do his or her best at least through our Prayers and supplications.

10. Furthermore, the importance of cooperation and communication among the followers of different faiths should be strengthened. There is no doubt that Jerusalem was the bastion of the messages of Allah, and the message of the Prophet was outside the sacred land in terms of physical presence but not in terms of the spirit and content of the message.

The Life of the Prophet Muhammad (pbuh) A Chronological Guide

1. Prophet's birth	In the spring season Monday is the agreed day. 1st year of Am-ul-Feel. 50 days after the event of the elephant, corresponding to 22nd April, 570 AD, 1st Jaith 628 Bikrami before sunrise, popularly known to be 12 Rabi I. The date is a matter of controversy, but most researchers lean to the 9th Rabi I, as Monday also falls on that date. Other dates suggest are 10 and 13 Rabi I. Some have also suggested 8. But the majority of scholars' view favours 9.
2. Nursing	At the age of 4 months. 2-3 days after birth, he was suckled by Thaubia, a slave girl of Abu Lahab. Permanent nursing period spent at the desert home of Halima S'adia
3. Death of Prophet's mother.	At the age of 6 years.
4. Death of his grandfather.	At the age of 8 years 2 months 10 days.
5. First journey to Syria with Hazrat Abu Talib.	At the age of 12 years 2 months. The episode of Bahira, the Monk, is connected with this journey.
6. Participation in the battle of Fajjar 1st time.	At the age of 15 or thereabout.
7. Participation in the battle of Fajjar second time.	Some time later, no date given.
8. Participation in Hilful Fazul, a reformist movement.	At the age of 16.
9. Second journey to Syria as a trader.	At the age of 23 or 24
10. Marriage with Hazrat Khadija.	At the age of 25 years 2 months.
11. Unseen secrets reveal themselves.	Seven years before Prophethood at the age of 33.
12. Arbitration.	At the age of 35. Arbitrated in the dispute about fixing the black stone which was amicably settled.
13. Prophethood.	At the age of 40 years 11 days, 9 Rabi I, corresponding to 12 February, 610 AD, Monday
14. Fajr and Asr Prayers , prescribed 2 Rakats each.	9 Rabi I, on the day of Prophethood.

15. Beginning of revelation of the Qur'an	18 Ramaza 1st year of Prophethood Friday, at night. Sura 'Alaq was revealed
16. Beginning of secrete preaching	House of Arquam Makhzoomi was made centre of movement. About 40 people accepted Islam during this period.
17. First public announcement of Prophethood.	At the end of 3rd year of Prophethood.
18. First wave of opposition, Ridicule Propaganda and mild oppression.	3rd to 5th year of Prophethood. During this period, deputations of Quraish went to pressurise Abu Talib and confabulations for opposition.
19. Second wave of intense opposition, Oppression.	5th to 7th year of Prophethood.
20. Migration to Abyssinia.	Rajab, 5th year of Prophethood.
21. Hazrat Hamza and Hazrat Umar embrace Islam.	Hazrat Umar accepted Islam 3 days after Hazrat Hamza.
22. Prophet's internment at Shi'b Abi Talib with the family of Hashim.	1st Muharram, 7th year of Prophethood.
23. End of internment and boycott.	End of 9th year of Prophethood.
24. Year of sorrow. Death of Hazrat Abu Talib and Hazrat Khadija	10th year of Prophethood.
25. Visit to Taif	Jumada II, 10th year of Prophethood.
26. Ascension (Miraj)	27ths Rajab, 10th year of Prophethood, Monday
27. Daily prayers five times a day prescribed.	27th Rajab, 10th year of Prophethood, Monday.
28. Beginning of Islam in Medina.	Zul hijja, 10th year of Prophethood
29. Deputation of Medina. Six people accept Islam.	Zul hijja, 12th year of Prophethood.
30. First pledge of Aqaba with 12 persons.	Zul hijja, 12th year of Prophethood.
31. Second pledge of Aqaba with 75 persons.	Zul hijjar, 13th year of Prophethood.
32. Migration: (a) From Mecca to the cave of Thaur	Safar 27, 13th year of Prophethood, Prophet's age was 53 years.
(b) Departure from Thaur	1st Rabi I, 13th year of Prophethood, Monday, 16th September, 622 A.D.
(c) Arrival at Quba.	8th Rabi I, 14th year of Prophethood Monday 23rd September, 622
(d) Entry into Medina.	14th year of Prophethood, Friday
33. Foundation of Masjid-i-Nabavi laid.	Rabi I, 1 H.
34. Addition of obligatory prayers	Rabi II, 1 H.

35. Brotherhood between Migrants and Ansars	First quarter, 1 H.
36. Establishment of Islamic State and constitutional agreement of Medina.	Middle of 1 H.
37. Defence system introduced.	Middle of 1 H. Patrol parties start.
38. Marriage with Hazrat Ayesha.	Shawwal, 1 H. Married in Mecca before migration but consummation at Medina after migration.
39. Islam of two elite, Abdullah ibn Salam, formerly Jew and Abu Qais Sarha bin Abi Anas, former Christian monk.	
40. Jihad ordered.	12 Safar 2 H., 1 year 2 months and 10 days after migration.
41. First military action Ghazwa Waddan.	Safar 2 H.
42. Pacts with outside clans Bani Damra, People of Bowat and Banu Madlaj.	Safar to Jumada II, 2 H.
43. Robbery of Kurz bin Jabir Fahri.	Rabi I, 2 H.
44. Nakhla episode, first frontier clash of Islamic party.	End of Rajab, 2 H. One non-Muslim killed and two taken prisoners and brought to Medina. The Prophet resented the action and made amends for it.
45. Salman Farsi accepts Islam.	2 H.
46. Beginning of Azan	2 H.
47. Zakat prescribed.	2 H.
48. Change of Qibla.	15th Shaban, 2 H. Monday
49. Ramazan fast prescribed.	1st Ramazan, 2 H. Wednesday.
50. Congregational prayer of Eid-ul Fitr, Fitra ordered.	1st Shawwal, 2 H.
51. Battle of Badr. First regular battle: Start from Medina.	8 Ramazan, 2 H. Wednesday
Battle.	17 Ramazan, 2 H.
Victorious entry into Medina.	20 Ramazan, 2 H.
52. Marriage of Hazrat Ali and Hazrat Fatima.	After the battle of Badr, 2 H.
53. Siege of Banu Qainuqa'.	Middle of Shawwal to beginning of Ziq'ada, 2 H.
54. Prophet's marriage with Hazrat Hafsa, daughter of Hazrat Umar.	3 H.
55. Marriage of Hazrat Usman with Hazrat Umme Kulsum, daughter of the Prophet.	3 H.
56. First order of prohibition of wine.	3 H.
57. End of Ka'ab bin Ashraf.	3 H.

58. Birth of Hazrat Hassan.	15 Ramazan, 3 H.
59. Battle of Uhud, Start from Medina.	5 Shawwal, 3 H. after Friday prayer.
Battle.	6 Shawwal, 3 H. Saturday.
Pursuit of Abu Sufian's army up to Hamra-ul-Asad.	7 Shawwal, 3 H. Sunday.
60. First order of prohibition of usury.	Soon after battle of Uhud.
61. Injunctions about orphans.	Soon after battle of Uhud.
62. Detailed laws of inheritance issued.	Soon after battle of Uhud.
63. Injunctions about marriage, rights of wives, prohibition of marriage with idolaters.	3 H.
64. Prophet's marriage with Ummul Masakin Zainab, daughter of Khozaima.	End of 3 H.
65. Episode of Raji'. Murder of 10 members of missionary deputation.	Safar, 4 H.
66. Ghazwa Banu Nodair.	Rabi I, 4 H.
67. Death of Hazrat Zainab, daughter of Khozaima.	Rabi I, 4 H.
68. Order of <i>Hijab</i>	1 Ziq'ada, 4 H. Friday.
69. Final order of prohibition of wine.	4 H.
70. Second Ghazwa of Badr.	Ziq'ada, 4 H. Abu Sufian did not turn up in keeping with his own challenge.
71. Ghazwa Dumatul Jandal	Rabi I, 5 H.
72. Ghazwa Banu Al-Mustalaq	3 Shaban, 5H.
73. Injunctions for Tayammum.	On the way to Ghazwa Banu Mustalaq.
74. Prophet's marriage with Hazrat Jowairia.	Shaban, 5 H.
75. Episode of Ifk.	Shaban, 5 H.
76. Enforcement of Penal Laws against fornication, slander etc.	5 H.
77. Ghazwa Ahzab.	Shawwal or Ziq'ada, 5 H.
78. Arrival of Daus deputation to Medina.	5 H.
79. Punishment of Banu Quraiza.	Zul hijja, 5 H.
80. Prophet's marriage with Zainab, daughter of Jahsh.	5 H.
81. Islam of Thamama bin Usal, chief of Najd.	6 H.
82. Treaty of Hudaibiya.	Ziq'ada, 6 H.

83. Return to Medina from Hudaibiya.	Zul hijja, 6 H.
84. Islam of Khalid bin Walid and Amr ibn-ul Aas.	Zul hijja, 6 H.
85. Beginning of international call-letters to rulers.	1st Muharram, 6 H. Wednesday.
86. Ghazwa Khyber.	Muharram, 7 H.
87. Prophet's marriage with Hazrat Safia.	Murharram, 7 H.
88. Return of Abyssinian migrants.	7 H.
89. Establishment of independent Muslim camp at Saiful Bahr.	7 H. By Muslim young men who were oppressed in Mecca but could not be allowed to stay at Medina according to Hudaibiya Treaty.
90. Raid by Saif-ul-Bahr on Quraish Caravan.	Safar, 7 H.
91. Postponed Umra performed	Ziq'ada, 7 H.
92. Detailed injunctions about marriage and divorce	7 H.
93. Marriage of the Prophet with Hazrat Maimuna at Mecca	7 H.
94. Islam of Jibila Ghassani.	7 H.
95 Ghazwa Muthah.	Jumada I, 8 H.
96. Violation of Hudaibiya pact by non-Muslims	Rajab, 8 H
97. Ghazwa of the conquest of Mecca, start from Medina.	10 Ramazan, 8 H. Wednesday.
Victorious entry into Mecca	20 Ramazan, 8 H.
Expedition of Hazrat Khalid to demolish the temple of Uzza at Nakhla.	Most probably 25 Ramazan, 8 H.
Expedition of Amr ibn-ul Aas to demolish the temple of Swa'a.	Ramazan, 8 H
Expedition of Sa'ad Ashhali to demolish temple of Manat.	Ramazan, 8 H
Stay in Mecca	Up to 9 Shawwal
Ghazwa Hunain.	Shawwal, 8 H
Siege of Taif	End of Shawwal to beginning of Ziq'ada, 8 H. about 18 or 20 days.
Distribution of booty at Ji'rana, and <i>Umra</i>	Ziq'ada, 8 H.
98. Final order of prohibition of usury	8 H. On the occasion of the victory of Mecca. Annulment of all demands of the amounts of interest.

99. Arrival of Suda deputation at Medina.	8 H.
100. Death of Hazrat Zainab, daughter of the Prophet.	8 H.
101. Organization of Zaka.	Beginning of Muharram, 9 H.
102. Ghazwa of Tabuk. Start of the Poor Contingent.	Rajab, 9 H.
103. Order about Jizia.	At the time of Tabuk.
104. Zerar Mosque set on fire.	On return from tabuk.
105. Islam of Ukaidir, chief of Dumatul Jandal.	9 H.
106. Apology by Ka'ab ibn Zuhair and his acceptance of Islam.	9 H.
107. Some deputations which came to Medina:	
Deputation of Azra.	Safar, 9 H.
Deputation of Baliy.	Rabi I, 9 H.
Deputation of Khaulan.	Shaban, 9 H.
Deputation of Thaqif.	9 H.
108. Haj prescribed. First Haj under Hazrat Abu Bakr.	9 Zul hijja, 9 H.
109. Proclamation of annulment of pacts of unlimited period.	10 Rabi II, 10 H.
110. Deputation of Maharib.	10 H.
Deputation of Mahamid.	10 H.
Deputation of Khaulan.	Shaban, 10 H.
Deputation of Naisan.	Ramazan, 10 H.
Deputation of Bani Haris bin Ka'ab	Shawwal, 10 H.
Deputation of Salaman.	Ramazan, 10 H.
111. Twenty days' retirement of the Prophet in the last Ramazan.	Ramazan, 10 H.
112. Musailima the liar's correspondence with the Prophet	10 H.
113. The Last Haj: start from Medina.	26 Ziq'ada, 10 H. Saturday between Zuhr and Asr.
Stay at Zulhailifa.	Night between Saturday and Sunday.
Putting on Ihram	Sunday at the time of Zuhr prayers
Arrival and stay at Zittowa.	Night of Sunday 4 Zul hijja, 10 H.

Start from Zittowa to Mecca	5 Zul hijja, after early morning prayer.
Entry into sacred Mosque.	5 Zul hijja, 10 H. at noon
Stay outside Mecca.	up to 8 Zul hijja, 10 H.
Start for Mina.	8 Zul hijja, 10 H. Thursday noon
Start from Mina to Arafah	9 Zul hijja, 10 H. Friday after sunrise.
Haj Address.	9 Zul hijja, 10 H. Friday afternoon.
Stop at Arafah.	9 Zul hijja, 10 H. after Zuhr and Asr prayers.
Start from Arafah to Muzdalifa.	9 Zul hijja, 10 H. after sunset, Friday.
From Muzdalifa to Masha'ar-i-Haram	10 Zul hijja, 10 H. Saturday after morning prayer.
From Masha'ar-i-Haram to Mina	10 Zul hijja, 10 H. before sunrise
Throwing of pebbles.	10 Zul hijja, 10 H. after sunrise till noon.
Address at Mina.	10 Zul hijja, 10 H. noon.
Sacrifice performed.	After address.
Start from Mina to Mecca.	10 Zul hijja, 10 H.
Return from Mina to Mecca.	10 Zul hijja, 10 H. evening.
Second address at Mina.	11 Zul hijja, 10 H.
Start from Mina to Mahsab or Abtah.	13 Zul hijja, 10 H. Tuesday.
Return from Mecca.	Night between 13th and 14th Zul hijja, 10 H.
114. Deputation of Nakh'a	Middle of Muharram, 11 H.
115. Order for Start of Usama's Army.	26 Safar, 11 H. Last military expedition ordered by the Prophet.
116. Beginning of the Prophet's fatal disease.	End of Safar, 11 H.
117. Period of seriousness of disease. Stay in Hazrat Ayesha's room.	7 days up to the time of passing away.
118. Last congregational prayer at the mosque and last address.	5 days before passing away, Thursday, Zuhr prayer.
119. Passing away.	12 Rabi I, 11 H. Monday, forenoon.
120. Burial in Hazrat Ayesha's room.	Night between 13 and 14 Rabi I, 11 H. Tuesday.